

LilyPond

The music typesetter

Usage

The LilyPond development team

This file explains how to execute the programs distributed with LilyPond version 2.27.2. In addition, it suggests some “best practices” for efficient usage.

For more information about how this manual fits with the other documentation, or to read this manual in other formats, see *Manuals in General Information*.
If you are missing any manuals, the complete documentation can be found at <https://lilypond.org/>.

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For LilyPond version 2.27.2

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Table of Contents

1 Running lilypond

1.1 Normal usage

1.2 Command-line usage

The PATH environment variable

Invoking lilypond

Basic command-line options for LilyPond

Advanced command-line options for LilyPond

Environment variables

Relocation

Relocation files

Relocation algorithm

1.3 Error messages

1.4 Common errors

Music runs off the page

An extra staff appears

Error message Unbound variable %

Error message FT_Get_Glyph_Name

Warning staff affinities should only decrease

Error message unexpected \new

Warning this voice needs a \voiceXx or \shiftXx setting

2 Updating files with convert-ly

2.1 Why does the syntax change?

2.2 Command-line preliminaries

2.3 Invoking convert-ly

2.4 Command-line options for convert-ly

2.5 Problems running convert-ly

2.6 Manual conversions

2.7 Writing code to support multiple versions

3 Running `lilypond-book`

- 3.1 An example of a musicological document
- 3.2 Integrating music and text
 - 3.2.1 LaTeX
 - 3.2.2 Texinfo
 - 3.2.3 HTML
 - 3.2.4 DocBook
- 3.3 Music fragment options
- 3.4 Invoking `lilypond-book`
- 3.5 Filename extensions
- 3.6 Parallel execution
- 3.7 `lilypond-book` templates
- 3.8 Sharing the table of contents
- 3.9 Alternative methods of mixing text and music

4 External programs

- 4.1 Point and click
 - 4.1.1 Configuring the system
 - Using GNOME
 - Extra configuration for Evince
 - Enabling point and click
 - Selective point-and-click
- 4.2 Text editor support
 - Emacs mode
 - Vim mode
 - Other editors
- 4.3 Converting from other formats
 - 4.3.1 Invoking `midi2ly`
 - 4.3.2 Invoking `musicxml2ly`
 - 4.3.3 Invoking `abc2ly`
 - 4.3.4 Invoking `etf2ly`
 - 4.3.5 Other formats
- 4.4 LilyPond output in other programs
 - 4.4.1 LuaTeX
 - 4.4.2 OpenOffice and LibreOffice
 - 4.4.3 `ly2video`
 - 4.4.4 Other programs
- 4.5 Independent includes
 - 4.5.1 MIDI articulation

5 Suggestions for writing files

- 5.1 General suggestions
- 5.2 Typesetting existing music
- 5.3 Large projects

5.4 Troubleshooting

5.5 Make and Makefiles

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B Index

1 Running lilypond

This chapter details the technicalities of running LilyPond.

1.1 Normal usage

Most users run LilyPond through a GUI; if you have not done so already, please read the Tutorial in *Learning Manual*. If you use an alternate editor to write LilyPond files, see the documentation for that program.

1.2 Command-line usage

This section contains extra information about using LilyPond on the command line. This may be desirable to pass extra options to the program. In addition, there are certain extra ‘helper’ programs (such as `midi2ly`) which are only available on the command line.

By ‘command line’, we mean the command line in the operating system. Windows users might be more familiar with the terms ‘DOS shell’ or ‘command shell’. macOS users might be more familiar with the terms ‘terminal’ or ‘console’.

Describing how to use this part of an operating system is outside the scope of this manual; please consult other documentation on this topic if you are unfamiliar with the command line.

You should use a command line that reads and writes Unicode in UTF-8 encoding. Today, this is the standard on Unix-like operating systems including macOS and GNU/Linux. On Windows, you can select UTF-8 by selecting an appropriate codepage: call

```
chcp 65001
```

once on the command line before running `lilypond.exe`. Please consult the internet how to permanently activate UTF-8 for the Windows console.¹

The PATH environment variable

[You can skip this section if you use a package manager like MacPorts to install LilyPond; PATH should already be set up correctly.]

Throughout the LilyPond manuals, examples simply show `lilypond` as the program to call. However, this only works if the PATH environment variable is adjusted so that LilyPond’s binary directory is included.

Assuming that you have unpacked a LilyPond binary package for version 2.27.2 within a directory `/home/me`, the binary directory to be added to PATH is

```
/home/me/lilypond-2.27.2/bin
```

On Windows, a typical directory might be

```
C:\Users\me\lilypond-2.27.2\bin
```

Please consult the documentation for your operating system (or do a search in the internet) how to actually modify PATH. In case you are updating from an older LilyPond version you should ensure that the old LilyPond binary directory is removed from PATH; after everything is done you can check with a call to `lilypond --version` whether the correct version gets found on the command line.

If, for whatever reason, adjusting PATH is not possible or appropriate, or if you have multiple LilyPond versions installed in parallel, use the full path to the binary, for example

```
/home/me/lilypond-2.27.2/bin/lilypond music.ly
```

Invoking lilypond

The lilypond executable may be called as follows from the command line.

```
lilypond [option]... file...
```

When invoked with a file name that has no extension, the `.ly` extension is tried first. To read input from stdin, use a dash (`-`) for *file*.

Note: On Windows prior to Windows 10 1903, LilyPond cannot handle Unicode file names.

When `filename.ly` is processed it produces `filename.pdf` as output by default. Several files can be specified; they are each processed independently.²

If `filename.ly` contains more than one `\book` block, the rest of the scores is output in numbered files, starting with `filename-1.pdf`. See *Output file names in Notation Reference* how to change the output file name and the file name suffix.

Using LilyPond with standard shell features

Since LilyPond is a command-line application, features of the ‘shell’ used for calling LilyPond can also be put to good use.

For example,

```
lilypond *.ly
```

processes all LilyPond files in the current directory.

Redirecting the console output (e.g., to a file) may also be useful:

```
lilypond file.ly 1> stdout.txt
lilypond file.ly 2> stderr.txt
lilypond file.ly &> all.txt
```

The above commands divert ‘normal’ output, ‘errors’ only, or ‘everything’, respectively, to text files. Consult the documentation for your particular shell, Command (Windows), Terminal or Console applications (macOS) to check whether output redirection is supported or if the syntax is different.

The following example searches and processes all input files in the current directory and all directories below it recursively. The output files are located in the same directory that the command was run in, rather than in the same directories as the original input files.

```
find . -name '*.ly' -exec lilypond '{}' \;
```

This should also work for macOS users.

A Windows user would run

```
forfiles /s /M *.ly /c "cmd /c lilypond @file"
```

entering these commands in a command prompt usually found under Start > Accessories > Command Prompt, or by typing in the search window ‘command prompt’.

Alternatively, an explicit path to the top-level of your folder containing all the sub-folders that have input files in them can be stated using the /p option;

```
forfiles /s /p C:\Documents\MyScores /M *.ly /c "cmd /c lilypond @file"
```

If there are spaces in the path to the top-level folder, then the whole path needs to be inside double quotes;

```
forfiles /s /p "C:\Documents\My Scores" /M *.ly /c "cmd /c lilypond @file"
```

Basic command-line options for LilyPond

Please bear in mind that option arguments with spaces in it must be *quoted*. For example, to write LilyPond’s output to a directory called ‘foo bar’, a user must add `-o "foo bar"` (or `--output="foo bar"`) to the command-line arguments of lilypond. Double quotes around such arguments work with virtually all command-line interpreters on both Windows and Unix-like operating systems (including macOS).

The following options are supported.

-d, --define-default=var[=val]

See [Advanced command-line options for LilyPond](#).

-e, --evaluate=expr

Evaluate the Scheme expression *expr* before parsing any .ly files. Multiple -e options may be given, they are evaluated sequentially.

The expression is evaluated in the guile-user module, so if you want to use a definition like (define-public a 42) as *expr*, use

```
lilypond -e "(define-public a 42)"
```

on the command line, and include

```
$(use-modules (guile-user))
```

at the top of the .ly file.

-E, --eps

Generate EPS files.

This option is equivalent to specifying `-dseparate-page-formats=eps` combined with `-dtall-page-formats=eps`.

-f, --format=*format*

The format of the (main) output file or files. Possible values for *format* are ps, pdf, png or svg.

Example: `lilypond -fpng foo.ly`

SVG internally uses a specific backend, and therefore cannot be obtained in the same run as other formats; using `-fsvg` or `--svg` is actually equivalent to using the `-dbackend=svg` option. See [Advanced command-line options for LilyPond](#).

-h, --help

Show a summary of usage.

-H, --header=*field*

Dump a header field to file `BASENAME.field`.

As an example, let's assume that you have an input file `foo.ly` containing

```
\header { title = "bar" }
\score { c1 }
```

The command

```
lilypond -H title foo.ly
```

then creates a plain text file `foo.title` containing the string `bar`.

-i, --init=*file*

Set init file to *file* (default: `init.ly`).

-I, --include=*directory*

Append *directory* to the search path for input files with relative paths. By default, only the current working directory gets searched.

Multiple `-I` options may be given. The search starts in the current working directory, and if the file to be included is not found the search continues in the directory given by the first `-I` option, then the directory in the second `-I` option, and so on.

Note: Using the tilde character (~) with the -I switch may produce unexpected results in some shells. Windows users need to include a trailing slash for the directory's path.

-j, --jail=user,group,jail,dir

[This option is only available if your operating system supports the chroot functionality. In particular, Windows doesn't support it.]

Run `lilypond` in a chroot jail.

The `--jail` option can be used for security when LilyPond formatting is being provided via a web server, or whenever LilyPond executes commands sent by external sources (see [Advanced command-line options for LilyPond](#)). Because LilyPond provides the ability to run Guile programs, it is essential in such scenarios to run it in a sandboxed way so that the file being compiled does not wreak havoc on the system, for example with

```
% too dangerous to write correctly
#(system "rm -rf /")
% malicious but not destructive
{ c4^$(ly:gulp-file "/etc/passwd") }
```

`--jail` is one way to achieve sandboxing. Another one is running LilyPond in a Docker container.

The `--jail` option works by changing the root of `lilypond` to *jail* just before starting the actual compilation process. The user and group are then changed to match those provided, and the current directory is changed to *dir*. This setup guarantees that it is not possible (at least in theory) to escape from the jail. Note that for `--jail` to work, `lilypond` must be run as root, which is usually accomplished in a safe way using `sudo`.

Setting up a jail can be a relatively complex matter, as we must be sure that LilyPond is able to find whatever it needs to compile the source *inside* the jail itself. A typical chroot jail comprises the following steps:

Setting up a separate filesystem

A separate filesystem should be created for LilyPond, so that it can be mounted with safe options such as `noexec`, `nodev`, and `nosuid`. In this way, it is impossible to run executables or to write directly to a device from LilyPond. If you do not want to create a separate partition, just create a file of reasonable size and use it to mount a loop device. A separate filesystem also guarantees that LilyPond cannot write more space than it is allowed.

Setting up a separate user

A separate user and group (say, `lily/lily`) with low privileges should be used to

run LilyPond inside the jail. There should be a single directory writable by this user, which should be passed in *dir*.

Preparing the jail

LilyPond needs to read a number of files while running. All these files are to be copied into the jail, under the same path they appear in the real root filesystem. The entire content of the LilyPond installation (e.g., `/usr/share/lilypond`) should be copied.

If problems arise, the simplest way to trace them down is to run LilyPond using `strace`, which allows you to determine which files are missing.

Running LilyPond

In a jail mounted with `noexec` it is impossible to execute any external program. Therefore LilyPond must be run with a backend that does not require any such program. As we have already mentioned, it must be run with superuser privileges (which, of course, it loses immediately), possibly using `sudo`. It is also good practice to limit the number of seconds of CPU time LilyPond can use (e.g., using `ulimit -t`), and, if your operating system supports it, the amount of memory that can be allocated.

-l, --loglevel=*level*

Set the verbosity of the console output to *level*. Possible values are:

NONE

No output at all, not even error messages.

ERROR

Only error messages, no warnings or progress messages.

WARN

Warnings and error messages, no progress.

BASIC

Basic progress messages (success), warnings and errors.

PROGRESS

All progress messages, warnings and errors.

INFO

Progress messages, warnings, errors and further execution information. This is the default.

DEBUG

All possible messages, including verbose debug output.

-o, --output=*file*

-o, --output=*folder*

Set the default output file to *file* or, if a folder with that name exists, direct the output to *folder*, taking the file name from the input file. The appropriate suffix is added (e.g., .pdf for PDF) in both cases.

-O, --pspdfopt=key

Set the PS/PDF output optimization to *key*. Possible values are:

size

Generate a very small PS/EPS/PDF document. This is the default.

Using this value is equivalent to setting LilyPond's Scheme command-line options

`-dmusic-font-encodings="#f"` and `-dgs-never-embed-fonts="#f"`.

TeX

Produce files that are optimized for inclusion in pdfTeX, LuaTeX, or XeTeX documents.

Using this value is equivalent to setting LilyPond's Scheme command-line options

`-dmusic-font-encodings="#t"` and `-dgs-never-embed-fonts="#f"`.

TeX-GS

If you want to include more than one PDF generated by LilyPond in a TeX document, use this option and postprocess the PDF generated by TeX with Ghostscript.

Using this value is equivalent to setting LilyPond's Scheme command-line options

`-dmusic-font-encodings="#t"` and `-dgs-never-embed-fonts="#t"`.

--ps

Generate PostScript. This option is equivalent to `-fps`.

--png

Generate pictures of each page, in PNG format. This option is equivalent to `-fpng`.

The resolution of the image may be set to *N* DPI with

```
-dresolution=N
```

--pdf

Generate PDF. This is the default, being equivalent to `-fpdf`.

-s, --silent

Show no progress, only error messages. This is equivalent to `-lERROR`.

--svg

Generate SVG files for each page. This option is equivalent to `-fsvg`.

-v, --version

Show version information.

-V, --verbose

Be verbose: show full paths of all files read, give timing information, etc. It is equivalent to `-lDEBUG`.

-w, --warranty

Show the warranty with which GNU LilyPond comes. (It comes with **NO WARRANTY!**)

Advanced command-line options for LilyPond

Option `-d` is the command-line interface to LilyPond's Scheme function `ly:set-option`. This means that all options listed here can also be set within `.ly` files.

-d, --define-default=option-name[=value]**-d, --define-default=no-option-name**

Set the equivalent internal Scheme symbol *option-name* to *value*. For example, the command-line option

```
-dbackend=svg
```

is equivalent to

```
#{ly:set-option 'backend 'svg)
```

in a LilyPond input file.

If *value* is not supplied, use `#t` as the value. The prefix `no-` may be added to *option-name* to switch 'off' an option, providing `#f` as the value. For example,

```
-dpoint-and-click="#f"
```

is the same as

```
-dno-point-and-click
```

[Note that the '#' character introduces a comment in many shells. For this reason it is recommended to always quote expressions that contain it.]

The following table lists all supported option names together with its values. Within Scheme code, option values can be read using function `ly:get-option`.

anti-alias-factor *num*

Render at a higher resolution (using factor *num*, which must be a positive integer ≤ 8) and scale down the result to prevent 'jaggies' in PNG images. Default: 1.

aux-files *bool*

If *bool* is `#t`, create `.tex`, `.texi`, and `.count` files. This option is primarily for use by `lilypond-book`. Default: `#f`.

backend *symbol*

Use *symbol* as the backend for LilyPond output. Possible values are:

ps

This is the default setting. PostScript files include TTF, Type1, and OTF fonts. No ‘subsetting’ of these fonts is done. Be aware that using ‘oriental’ character sets like Japanese can lead to very large file sizes.

For PDF output, the `ps` backend is used, too; the resulting PS data is post-processed by Ghostscript’s `ps2pdf` script, which also does font subsetting by default.

cairo

This creates graphics output through the Cairo library. This backend can output PS, EPS, PDF, PNG, and SVG.

svg

Scalable Vector Graphics. A single SVG file is created for every page of output. Music glyphs are encoded as vector graphics, but text fonts are *not* embedded in the SVG files. Any SVG viewer will therefore need the relevant text fonts to be available to it for proper rendering of both text and lyrics. It is recommended to not use font ‘lists’ or ‘aliases’ in case an SVG viewer is unable to handle them.

clip-systems *bool*

If *bool* is `#t`, extract music fragments out of a score. This requires that the `clip-regions` function has been defined within the `\layout` block. See *Extracting fragments of music in Notation Reference*. No fragments are extracted though if used with the `-dno-print-pages` option. Default: `#f`.

compile-scheme-code *bool*

Use the Guile compiler to run Scheme code, instead of the evaluator. For more information, see *Debugging Scheme code in Extending*.

crop *bool*

If *bool* is `#t`, a second PDF file gets created (with extension `.cropped.pdf`), together with a rendered image of it (with extension `.cropped.png`). This output file fits all the music and headers, without margins, into a single, possibly tall page. If option `--svg` is set, an additional SVG file (with extension `.cropped.svg`) is produced instead. If option `--eps` or `--ps` is set, a cropped EPS file (with extension `.cropped.eps`) is produced instead of a cropped PDF. Default: `#f`.

As a feature of LilyPond, the dimensions of the cropped output file are always rounded up to integer (PostScript) big points; this might cause a little bit of whitespace at the right margin. To avoid that, set the `line-width` paper variable to an integer big point value like `450\bp`.

Note that currently this option is not well suited for multi-system output since vertical space between systems gets removed.

datadir *string*

Prefix for data files. This is a read-only option; setting it has no effect.

debug-eval *bool*

If *bool* is *#t*, use the debugging Scheme evaluator, which prints backtraces with line numbers on errors. Default: *#f*, or *#t* when using *--verbose*.

debug-skylines *bool*

If *bool* is *#t*, debug skylines. Default: *#f*.

delete-intermediate-files *bool*

If *bool* is *#t*, delete the unusable, intermediate *.ps* files created during compilation.

Default: *#t*.

embed-source-code *bool*

If *bool* is *#t*, embed the LilyPond source files inside the generated PDF document.

Default: *#f*.

eps-box-padding *num*

Pad left edge of the output EPS bounding box by *num* millimeters. Default: *#f* (meaning no bounding box padding).

first *string*

Only show music with a length given by *string* at the beginning. This is equivalent to

```
showFirstLength = string
```

if inserted at the beginning of the input file. If both *-dfirst* and *showFirstLength* are set, the command-line option takes precedence. See *Extracting fragments of music in Notation Reference*. Default: *#f*.

font-export-dir *string*

Set directory for exporting fonts as PostScript files to *string*. This is useful when you want to create a PDF without embedded fonts first and later embed the fonts with Ghostscript as shown below.

```
$ lilypond -dfont-export-dir=fontdir \
           -dgs-never-embed-fonts foo.ly
$ gs -q -dBATCH -dNOPAUSE -sDEVICE=pdfwrite \
     -sOutputFile=foo.embedded.pdf foo.pdf fontdir/*.font.ps
```

Note: Unlike *font-ps-resdir*, this method cannot embed CID fonts with Ghostscript 9.26 and later.

Note: Similar to *font-ps-resdir*, this option skips TrueType fonts because embedding TrueType fonts might cause garbled characters. To avoid garbling characters, use *gs-never-embed-fonts*, as this embeds TrueType fonts despite its name.

Default: *#f* (meaning no export directory).

font-ps-resdir *string*

Set directory (as *string*) to build a subset of the PostScript resource directory to be used for embedding fonts later. This is useful when you want to create a PDF without embedded fonts first and later embed the fonts with Ghostscript as shown below.

```
$ lilypond -dfont-ps-resdir=resdir \
           -dgs-never-embed-fonts foo.ly
$ gs -q -dBATCH -dNOPAUSE -sDEVICE=pdfwrite \
     -I resdir -I resdir/Font \
     -sOutputFile=foo.embedded.pdf foo.pdf
```

Note: It is better not to specify a directory that contains the name `Resource` because it has a special meaning when specified with the `-I` option for Ghostscript.

Note: Unlike `font-export-dir`, this method can embed CID fonts with Ghostscript 9.26 and later.

Note: Similar to `font-export-dir`, this option skips TrueType fonts because embedding TrueType fonts might cause garbled characters. To avoid garbling characters, use `gs-never-embed-fonts`, as this embeds TrueType fonts despite its name.

Default: `#f` (meaning no subset directory).

`gs-load-fonts` *bool*

If *bool* is `#t`, load fonts via Ghostscript. This option makes LilyPond's output files contain only references to all fonts, which must be resolved to real fonts in a post-processing step by Ghostscript. Default: `#f`.

`gs-load-lily-fonts` *bool*

If *bool* is `#t`, load LilyPond fonts via Ghostscript. This option makes LilyPond's output files contain only references to its music fonts, which must be resolved to real fonts in a post-processing step by Ghostscript. All other fonts are still output as usual. Default: `#f`.

`gs-never-embed-fonts` *bool*

If *bool* is `#t`, make Ghostscript embed only TrueType fonts and no other font format. Default: `#f`.

`help` *bool*

If *bool* is `#t`, show a help screen and exit. Default: `#f`.

`include-book-title-preview` *bool*

If *bool* is `#t`, include book titles in preview images. Default: `#t`.

`include-eps-fonts` *bool*

If *bool* is `#t`, include fonts in separate-system EPS files. Default: `#t`.

`include-settings` *string*

Include file *string* for global settings, which is included before the score is processed. This option can be passed multiple times to include several files. Default: not set (meaning no global settings file).

`job-count` *num*

Process in parallel, using *num* jobs (*num* being a positive integer). Default: `#f` (meaning no parallel processing).

last *string*

Only show music with a length given by *string* at the end. This is equivalent to

```
showLastLength = string
```

if inserted at the beginning of the input file. If both `-dlast` and `showLastLength` are set, the command-line option takes precedence. See Extracting fragments of music in *Notation Reference*. Default: `#f`.

log-file *string*

Redirect output to the log file *string*.log. Default: `#f` (meaning no log file).

max-markup-depth *num*

Set maximum depth for the markup tree to value *num* (being a non-negative integer). If a markup has more levels, assume it will not terminate on its own, print a warning, and return a null markup instead. Default: 1024.

midi-extension *string*

Set the default file extension for MIDI output files to *.string*. Default: `"midi"`.

music-strings-to-paths *bool*

If *bool* is `#t`, convert text strings to paths when glyphs belong to a music font. Default: `#f`.

paper-size *string*

Set default paper size to *string*. Default: `"a4"`.

pixmap-format *string*

Set Ghostscript's output format for pixel images to *string*. Default: `"png16m"`.

png-width *width***png-height *height***

For PNG output, set the width and height (in pixels) of the created image file. If one of the options is missing, the other dimension is computed according to the EPS bounding box, retaining the aspect ratio. Both *width* and *height* must be non-negative integers.

In addition to `--png`, either `--eps`, `-dcrop`, or `-dpreview` should be used to get proper image scaling without clipping.

Option `-dresolution` is ignored.

Note that there is a bug in Ghostscript versions up to 9.52 for these two options: It produces empty PNG images if the height is larger than the width.

Default: 0 for both *width* and *height* (meaning both dimensions are derived from the EPS bounding box).

point-and-click *value*

If *value* is `#t`, add 'point & click' links to PDF and SVG output.

There are more possible option values; see [Point and click](#). Default: #t.

preview *bool*

If *bool* is #t, create preview images in addition to normal output. Default: #f.

For input file name *file* and output format *fmt*, it generates an output file having the name *file.preview.fmt*, containing the titles and the first system of music. If \book or \bookpart blocks are used, the titles of \book, \bookpart or \score will appear in the output, including the first system of every \score block if the \paper variable print-all-headers is set to #t.

To suppress the usual output, use the -dprint-pages or -dno-print-pages options according to your requirements.

print-pages *bool*

If *bool* is #t, generate full pages. Default: #t.

Option -dno-print-pages is useful in combination with -dpreview or -dcrop.

protected-scheme-parsing *bool*

If *bool* is #t, continue when errors in inline Scheme code are caught in the parser. If set to #f, halt on errors and print a stack trace. Default: #t.

read-file-list *bool*

If *bool* is #t, handle all file arguments on the command line as lists of LilyPond input files to be processed, with one input file per line in these lists. Default: #f.

relative-includes *bool*

When processing an \include command, look for the included file relative to the current file if *bool* is #t. If set to #f, look for the file relative to the root file. Default: #t.

resolution *num*

Set resolution for generating PNG pixmaps to *num* dpi (which must be a positive number). Default: 101.

separate-log-files *bool*

For input files *file1.ly*, *file2.ly*, ..., output log data to files *file1.log*, *file2.log*, ..., if *bool* is #t. Default: #f.

separate-page-formats *string*

Comma-separated list of formats (svg, pdf, png, or eps) to use for the separate page images in lilypond-book. See [Other programs](#). Default: #f.

show-available-fonts *bool*

If *bool* is #t, list available font names as delivered by the fontconfig library. Appended to this list LilyPond displays the configuration settings of fontconfig itself. Default: #f.

staff-size *num*

Set global staff size to *num* points (which must be a positive number). This is equivalent to

```
#(set-global-staff-size num)
```

if inserted at the beginning of the input file. Default: 20 pt.

strip-output-dir *bool*

If *bool* is #t, don't use the directory part from input file paths while constructing output file names. Default: #t.

strokeadjust *bool*

If *bool* is #t, force PostScript stroke adjustment. This option is mostly relevant when a PDF is generated from PostScript output (stroke adjustment is usually enabled automatically for low-resolution bitmap devices). Without this option, PDF previewers tend to produce widely inconsistent stem widths at resolutions typical for screen display. However, the option does not noticeably affect print quality and causes large file size increases in PDF files. Default: #f.

tall-page-formats *string*

Comma-separated list of formats (svg, pdf, png, or eps) to use for the 'tall page' image in lilypond-book. See [Other programs](#). Default: #f.

use-paper-size-for-page *bool*

If *bool* is #t, each page is set to the paper size, possibly cropping parts that extend beyond the paper. Setting it #f resizes the page to contain the content as necessary. Default: #t.

verbose *bool*

Verbosity level. This is a read-only option; setting it has no effect.

warning-as-error *bool*

If *bool* is #t, change all warning and 'programming error' messages into errors. Default: #f.

Environment variables

lilypond recognizes the following environment variables:

LILYPOND_DATADIR

This specifies a directory where locale messages and data files are looked up by default, overriding locations defined either at compile-time or computed dynamically at run-time (see [Relocation](#)). The directory should contain subdirectories called ly, ps, tex, etc.

LILYPOND_LOCALEDIR

Specify the directory where locale-specific files are located. This overrides the value derived from LILYPOND_DATADIR.

LILYPOND_RELOCDIR

Specify the directory where relocation files are located. This overrides the value derived from the location of the lilypond binary.

LANG

The language for LilyPond data sent to `stdout` and `stderr`, for example progress reports, warning messages, or debug output. Example: `LANG=de`.

LILYPOND_LOGLEVEL

The default loglevel. If LilyPond is called without an explicit loglevel (i.e., no `--loglevel` command-line option), this value is used.

LILYPOND_GC_YIELD

A variable, as a percentage, that tunes memory management behavior. A higher value means the program uses more memory, a smaller value means more CPU time is used. The default value is 70.

TMPDIR

This specifies the temporary directory in GNU/Linux and macOS. Default is `/tmp`. It is the directory where intermediate files (such as PostScript files) are saved during compilation. Overriding this variable might be useful, for example, if the user running `lilypond` does not have write access to the default temporary directory. Example:

`TMPDIR=~ /foo`.

Relocation

Most programs in the Unix world use default directories for its data that are determined at configure time before compilation. LilyPond is no exception; for example, a typical installation puts the `lilypond` binary into `/usr/bin` and all files specific to LilyPond into subdirectories of `/usr/share/lilypond/2.27.2/` (assuming that the current version is 2.27.2).

While this approach works fine for manual compilation and platforms that come with standardized package managers, it can cause issues where such managers are not common or not used by default. Typical examples of such platforms are Windows and macOS, where users expect that application bundles can be installed anywhere.

The common solution to this problem is relocation support: Instead of using hard-coded paths to data files, locations of the necessary support files are computed at run time *relative to the executed binary*.

Relocation files

There's actually a second mechanism for run-time configuration: LilyPond heavily relies on external programs and libraries, in particular the 'FontConfig' and 'Guile' libraries to find system fonts and handle Scheme files, respectively, and the `gs` program to convert PS data to PDF files. All of them must be configured also to locate its relevant data files. To do that, the `lilypond` program parses all files in a directory called `relocate` (if it exists; see below where this directory is searched for) to manipulate environment variables, which in turn control those external libraries and programs. The format of such relocation files is simple; each line has the syntax

```
command key=value
```

and empty lines get ignored.

The *command* directive is one of the following.

set

Unconditionally set environment variable *key* to *value*. This overrides a previously set value.

set?

Set environment variable *key* to *value* only if *key* isn't defined yet. In other words, it doesn't override a previously set value.

setdir

If *value* is a directory, unconditionally set environment variable *key* to *value*. Otherwise, emit a warning.

setfile

If *value* is a file, unconditionally set environment variable *key* to *value*. Otherwise, emit a warning.

prependdir

Prepend directory *value* to the list of directories in environment variable *key*. If *key* doesn't exist it gets created.

Environment variables (marked with a leading dollar sign) are allowed in *value* and get expanded before the directive is executed.

Here are two examples of relocation file entries.

```
set? FONTCONFIG_FILE=$INSTALLER_PREFIX/etc/fonts/fonts.conf
prependdir GUILF_LOAD_PATH=$INSTALLER_PREFIX/share/guile/1.8
```

Multiple lines setting the same environment variable should be avoided in relocation files since the parsing order of files in the `relocate` directory is arbitrary.

Relocation algorithm

LilyPond uses the following algorithm to find its data files.

1.

Compute the directory where the currently executed `lilypond` binary is located. Let's call this `bindir`. Set (internal) environment variable `INSTALLER_PREFIX` to `bindir/..` (i.e., the parent directory of `bindir`).

2.

Check environment variable `LILYPOND_DATADIR`. If it is set, use its value for LilyPond's data directory, `datadir`. Otherwise use either `$INSTALLER_PREFIX/share/lilypond/`

version (with *version* being the current LilyPond version) or
\$INSTALLER_PREFIX/share/lilypond/current.

3.

Check environment variable LILYPOND_LOCALEDIR. If it is set, use its value for LilyPond's locale data directory, *localedir*. Otherwise use \$INSTALLER_PREFIX/share/locale.

4.

Check environment variable LILYPOND_RELOCDIR. If it is set, use its value for the directory of LilyPond's relocation files, *relocdir*. Otherwise use \$INSTALLER_PREFIX/etc/relocate.

5.

If *datadir* doesn't exist, use a compile-time value instead. Ditto for *localedir* (but not for *relocdir*, since it doesn't make sense to have that).

6.

If *relocdir* exists, process all files in this directory (see [Relocation files](#)).

1.3 Error messages

Different error messages can appear while compiling a file:

Warning

Something looks suspect. If you are requesting something out of the ordinary then you will understand the message, and can ignore it. However, warnings usually indicate that something is wrong with the input file.

Error

Something is definitely wrong. The current processing step (parsing, interpreting, or formatting) will be finished, but the next step will be skipped.

Fatal error

Something is definitely wrong, and LilyPond cannot continue. This happens rarely. The most usual cause is misinstalled fonts.

Scheme error

Errors that occur while executing Scheme code are caught by the Scheme interpreter. If running with the verbose option (`-v` or `--verbose`) then a call trace of the offending function call is printed.

Programming error

There was some internal inconsistency. These error messages are intended to help the programmers and debuggers. Usually, they can be ignored. Sometimes, they come in such big quantities that they obscure other output.

Aborted (core dumped)

This signals a serious programming error that caused the program to crash. Such errors are considered critical. If you stumble on one, send a bug-report.

If warnings and errors can be linked to some part of the input file, then error messages have the following form

```
filename:lineno:columnno: message
offending input line
```

A line-break is inserted in the offending line to indicate the column where the error was found. For example,

```
test.ly:2:19: error: not a duration: 5
{ c'4 e'
      5 g' }
```

These locations are LilyPond's best guess about where the warning or error occurred, but (by their very nature) warnings and errors occur when something unexpected happens. If you can't see an error in the indicated line of your input file, try checking one or two lines above the indicated position.

Please note that diagnostics can be triggered at any point during the many stages of processing. For example if there are parts of the input that are processed multiple times (i.e., in midi and layout output), or if the same music variable is used in multiple contexts the same message may appear several times. Diagnostics produced at a 'late' stage (i.e., bar checks) might also be issued multiple times.

See [Common errors](#) for more information about errors.

1.4 Common errors

The error conditions described below occur often, yet the cause is not obvious or easily found. Once seen and understood, they are easily handled.

Music runs off the page

Music running off the page over the right margin or appearing unduly compressed is almost always due to entering an incorrect duration on a note, causing the final note in a measure to extend over the bar line. It is not invalid if the final note in a measure does not end on the automatically entered bar line, as the note is simply assumed to carry over into the next measure. But if a long sequence of such carry-over measures occurs the music can appear compressed or may flow off the page because automatic line breaks can be inserted only at the end of complete measures, i.e., where all notes end before or at the end of the measure.

Note: An incorrect duration can cause line breaks to be inhibited, leading to a line of highly compressed music or music which flows off the page.

The incorrect duration can be found easily if bar checks are used, see Bar and bar number checks in *Notation Reference*.

If you actually intend to have a series of such carry-over measures you will need to insert an invisible bar line where you want the line to break. For details, see Bar lines in *Notation Reference*.

An extra staff appears

If contexts are not created explicitly with `\new` or `\context`, they will be silently created as soon as a command is encountered which cannot be applied to an existing context. In simple scores the automatic creation of contexts is useful, and most of the examples in the LilyPond manuals take advantage of this simplification. But occasionally the silent creation of contexts can give rise to unexpected new staves or scores. For example, it might be expected that the following code would cause all note heads within the following staff to be colored red, but in fact it results in two staves with the note heads remaining the default black in the lower staff.

```
\override Staff.NoteHead.color = #red
\new Staff { a' }
```



LilyPond v2.27.2

This is because a `Staff` context does not exist when the override is processed, so one is implicitly created and the override is applied to it, but then the `\new Staff` command creates another, separate, staff into which the notes are placed. The correct code to color all note heads red is

```
\new Staff {
  \override Staff.NoteHead.color = #red
  a'
}
```



LilyPond v2.27.2

Error message Unbound variable %

This error message will appear at the bottom of the console output or log file together with a “Guile signalled an error ...” message every time a Scheme routine is called which (invalidly) contains a *LilyPond* rather than a *Scheme* comment.

LilyPond comments begin with a percent sign, (%), and must not be used within Scheme routines. Scheme comments begin with a semi-colon, (;).

Error message `FT_Get_Glyph_Name`

This error messages appears in the console output or log file if an input file contains a non-ASCII character and was not saved in UTF-8 encoding. For details, see Text encoding in *Notation Reference*.

Warning `staff affinities should only decrease`

This warning can appear if there are no staves in the printed output, for example if there are just a `ChordName` context and a `Lyrics` context as in a lead sheet. The warning messages can be avoided by making one of the contexts behave as a staff by inserting

```
\override VerticalAxisGroup.staff-affinity = ##f
```

at its start. For details, see “Spacing of non-staff lines” in Flexible vertical spacing within systems in *Notation Reference*.

Error message `unexpected \new`

A `\score` block must contain a *single* music expression. If instead it contains several `\new Staff`, `\new StaffGroup` or similar contexts introduced with `\new` without them being enclosed in either curly brackets, { ... }, or double angle brackets, << ... >>, like this:

```
\score {
  % Invalid! Generates error: syntax error, unexpected \new
  \new Staff { ... }
  \new Staff { ... }
}
```

the error message will be produced.

To avoid the error, enclose all the `\new` statements in curly or double angle brackets.

Using curly brackets will introduce the `\new` statements sequentially:

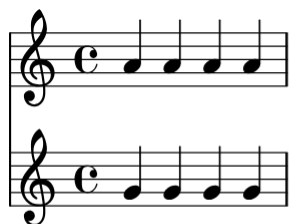
```
\score {
  {
    \new Staff { a' a' a' a' }
    \new Staff { g' g' g' g' }
  }
}
```



LilyPond v2.27.2

but more likely you should be using double angle brackets so the new staves are introduced in parallel, i.e., simultaneously:

```
\score {
  <<
    \new Staff { a' a' a' a' }
    \new Staff { g' g' g' g' }
  >>
}
```



LilyPond v2.27.2

Warning this voice needs a `\voiceXx` or `\shiftXx` setting

If notes from two different voices with stems in the same direction occur at the same musical moment, but the voices have no voice-specific shifts specified, the warning message ‘warning: this voice needs a `\voiceXx` or `\shiftXx` setting’ will appear when compiling the LilyPond file. This warning will appear even when the notes have no visible stems, e.g., whole notes, if the stems for shorter notes at the same pitch would be in the same direction.

Remember that the stem direction depends on the position of the note on the staff unless the stem direction is specified, for example by using `\voiceOne`, etc. In this case the warning will appear only when the stems happen to be in the same direction, i.e., when the notes are in the same half of the staff.

By placing the notes in voices with stem directions and shifts specified, for example by using `\voiceOne`, etc., these warnings may be avoided.

Notes in higher numbered voices, `\voiceThree`, etc., are automatically shifted to avoid clashing note columns. This causes a visible shift for notes with stems, but whole notes are not visibly shifted unless an actual clash of the note heads occurs, or when the voices cross over from their natural order (when `\voiceThree` is higher than `\voiceOne`, etc.).

See also

Explicitly instantiating voices in *Learning Manual*, Real music example in *Learning Manual*, Single-staff polyphony in *Notation Reference*, Collision resolution in *Notation Reference*.

Footnotes

(1) <https://stackoverflow.com/a/57134096/1276195> for example gives a pretty exhaustive answer.

(2) The status of Guile is not reset after processing a .ly file, so be careful not to change any system defaults from within Scheme.

2 Updating files with `convert-ly`

As LilyPond is improved, the syntax (input language) of some commands and functions can change. This usually results in unexpected errors, warnings, or even wrong output when input files, previously created for older versions of LilyPond, are then used with later versions.

To help with this, the `convert-ly` command can be used to upgrade older input files to the newer syntax.

2.1 Why does the syntax change?

Syntax changes are often made to make the LilyPond input code simpler for both reading and writing, but occasionally changes are made to accommodate new features or enhancements to existing functions.

Here is a real example to illustrate this.

All `\paper` and `\layout` property names are supposed to be written in the form *first-second-third*. However, in LilyPond version 2.11.60, it was noticed that the `printallheaders` property did not follow this convention. Should this property be left alone (confusing new users with an inconsistent format)? Or should it be changed (annoying old users with existing LilyPond input files)? The decision was eventually made to change the name of the property to `print-all-headers`, and by using the `convert-ly` command old users had a way to automatically update their existing input files.

Unfortunately, the `convert-ly` command is not capable to manage all syntax changes. For example, accents and non-English characters were entered using standard LaTeX notation in versions of LilyPond before 2.6; words like ‘Noël’ (which is ‘Christmas’ in French) had to be entered as `No\"e1`. Starting with LilyPond 2.6, the special letter ‘ë’ must be entered directly as a UTF-8 character. Because `convert-ly` cannot convert LaTeX special characters into UTF-8 characters, older LilyPond input files have to be edited manually to take care of that.

The conversion rules of the `convert-ly` command work by using text pattern matching and replacement (rather than ‘understanding’ the context of what it is changing within a given input file). This has several consequences:

-

The reliability of the conversion depends on the quality of each applied rule set and on the complexity of the respective change. Sometimes conversions may require additional, manual fixes, so the original input files should be kept for comparison just in case.

-

Only conversions to newer syntax changes are possible: there are no rule sets to go back to older versions of LilyPond. As a consequence, input files should only be upgraded when older versions of LilyPond are no longer being maintained. Again, the original data should be kept just in case, perhaps by using version control systems like Git to help maintain multiple versions of your input files.

.

LilyPond is quite robust when processing ‘creatively’ placed or omitted whitespace, but the rules used by `convert-ly` often make some stylistic assumptions. For painless upgrades it is therefore advised to follow the input style as used in the LilyPond manuals, particularly as the examples in the manuals themselves are all upgraded using the `convert-ly` command.

2.2 Command-line preliminaries

This and the following sections only cover the command-line usage of `convert-ly`. GUI applications like Frescobaldi have their own interfaces to `convert-ly`.

By ‘command line’, we mean the command line in the operating system. Windows users might be more familiar with the terms ‘DOS shell’ or ‘command shell’. macOS users might be more familiar with the terms ‘terminal’ or ‘console’.

Describing how to use this part of an operating system is outside the scope of this manual; please consult other documentation on this topic if you are unfamiliar with the command line.

See [The PATH environment variable](#) how to set up the operating system so that `convert-ly` can be used on the command line without specifying a path.

Additional setup for Windows

[Non-Windows users can skip this section; Windows users who have a Python interpreter already installed (version 3.8 or higher) can skip this section, too.]

`convert-ly` is actually a Python script called `convert-ly.py`. In the LilyPond binary bundle for Windows it is located in the same directory as the `lilypond.exe` binary and a Python interpreter, `python.exe`. Assuming that you have unpacked version 2.27.2 within a directory `C:\Users\me` and `PATH` is correctly set up, it would be still necessary to say

```
python C:\Users\me\lilypond-2.27.2\bin\convert-ly.py myfile.ly
```

which is tedious to type.

Three steps are necessary to allow the omission of both the interpreter (`python.exe`) and the `.py` extension.³

1.

On the command line, say

```
assoc .py=PythonScript
```

to associate the extension `.py` with the file type 'PythonScript'.

2.

As the next command, say

```
ftype PythonScript=C:\Users\me\lilypond-2.27.2\bin\python.exe %1 %*
```

to make files of type 'PythonScript' be handled by LilyPond's `python.exe`. You have to adjust the path to the actual location, and don't omit the trailing '`%1 %*`'!

3.

Modify the `PATHEXT` environment variable and add `.py` to already present entries. Do this in exactly the same way as you have already done with `PATH`.

Now close the command line and open it again, then test whether `convert-ly --version` works.

2.3 Invoking `convert-ly`

The `convert-ly` command uses the `\version` number in the input file to detect older versions. In most cases it is sufficient just to run

```
convert-ly -e myfile.ly
```

in the directory containing the input file; this upgrades `myfile.ly` in-place and preserves the original file by renaming it to `myfile.ly~`. The `\version` number in the upgraded input file, along with any required syntax updates, is also changed.

When run, the `convert-ly` command outputs the version numbers of which conversions have been made to. If no version numbers are listed in the output for the file, it is already up to date and using the latest LilyPond syntax.

Note: For each new version of LilyPond, a new `convert-ly` command is created. However, not every version of LilyPond needs syntax changes for its input files from the version before. This means that the `convert-ly` command only converts input files up to the latest syntax change it has and this, in turn, may mean that the `\version` number left in the upgraded input file is sometimes lower than the version of the `convert-ly` command itself.

To convert all input files in a single directory, use

```
convert-ly -e *.ly
```

as a command. To handle all input files that reside in different subdirectories, try

```
find . -name '*.ly' -exec convert-ly -e '{}' \;
```

to recursively search and convert them in the current directory and all directories below it. The converted files will be located in the same directory along with their renamed originals.

On Windows, execute

```
forfiles /s /M *.ly /c "cmd /c convert-ly -e @file"
```

instead. The `forfiles` command also accepts an explicit path to the top level of your folder containing all the sub-folders that have input files in them by using the `/p` option.

```
forfiles /s /p C:\Documents\MyScores /M *.ly /c "cmd /c convert-ly -e @file"
```

If there are spaces in the path to the top-level folder, the whole path needs to be inside double quotes, for example

```
forfiles /s /p "C:\Documents\My Scores" /M *.ly /c "cmd /c convert-ly -e @file"
```

2.4 Command-line options for `convert-ly`

The program is invoked as follows:

```
convert-ly [option]... filename...
```

By default, `convert-ly` writes its data to standard output.

The following options can be given:

--version

Show version number and exit.

-h, --help

Show usage help and exit.

-d, --diff-version-update

Increase the `\version` string only if the file has actually been changed. In that case, the version header will correspond to the version after the last actual change. An unstable version number will be rounded up to the next stable version number unless that would exceed the target version number. Without this option, the version will instead reflect the last *attempted* conversion.

-e, --edit

Apply the conversions directly to the input file, modifying it in-place. If the original file is called `myfile.ly`, a backup is retained under the name `myfile.ly~`, i.e., a tilde character gets appended. This backup file may be a hidden file on some operating systems.

If you want the converted output to be stored under a different name, redirect the standard output to a file.

```
convert-ly myfile.ly > mynewfile.ly
```

See also option `--backup-numbered`.

-b, --backup-numbered

When used with the `'-e'` option, number the backup files so that no previous version is overwritten. Assuming the input file is called `myfile.ly`, try to store the backup in `myfile.ly.~1~`. If it exists, try `myfile.ly.~2~` instead, etc. The backup files may be hidden on some operating systems.

-f, --from=*from-patchlevel*

Set the version to convert from. If this is not set, `convert-ly` will guess it on the basis of the (first) `\version` string in the file. Example: `--from=2.10.25`

-h, --help

Print usage help.

-l *loglevel*, --loglevel=*loglevel*

Set the output verbosity to *loglevel*. Possible values, in upper case, are PROGRESS (the default), NONE, WARN, ERROR, and DEBUG.

-n, --no-version

Normally, `convert-ly` adds a `\version` indicator to the output. Specifying this option suppresses this.

-c, --current-version

By default, `convert-ly` updates the `\version` string to the lowest necessary version. If this option is given, the current LilyPond version (2.27.2) is used instead.

-s, --show-rules

Show conversion descriptions and exit. The amount of information can be adjusted with options `--from` and `--to`.

-t, --to=*to-patchlevel*

Explicitly set which `\version` to convert to, otherwise the default is the most current value. It must be higher than the starting version.

```
convert-ly --to=2.14.1 myfile.ly
```

-v, --verbose

Display rule descriptions during conversion.

-w, --warranty

Show warranty and copyright and exit.

To upgrade LilyPond fragments in Texinfo files, use

```
convert-ly --from=... --to=... --no-version *.itely
```

To see the changes in the LilyPond syntax between two versions, use

```
convert-ly --from=... --to=... -s
```

2.5 Problems running `convert-ly`

If an input (or output) file name contains spaces it is necessary to surround the file name with double quotes.

```
convert-ly "D:/My Scores/Ode.ly" > "D:/My Scores/new Ode.ly"
```

If the invocation of `convert-ly -e *.ly` fails because the expanded command line becomes too long, the `convert-ly` command may be placed in a loop instead. This example for UNIX upgrades all `.ly` files in the current directory

```
for f in *.ly; do convert-ly -e $f; done
```

For Windows, the corresponding command is

```
for %x in (*.ly) do convert-ly.py -e "%x"
```

in the command prompt window.

As discussed earlier, not all language changes are handled. In particular, automatically updating Scheme and LilyPond Scheme interfaces is quite unlikely; be prepared to tweak Scheme code manually.

2.6 Manual conversions

In theory, a program like `convert-ly` could handle any syntax change. After all, a computer program interprets the old version and the new version, so another computer program can translate one file into another.⁴

However, the LilyPond project has limited resources: not all conversions are performed automatically. If `convert-ly` is not able to handle a syntax change, it emits a warning like the following (from the 2.23.12 conversion rule).

```
Not smart enough to convert music following \fine.
```

```
Warning: \fine no longer enforces the end of the music.
If your piece has music following \fine that you want to
exclude when it is unfolded, use \volta to exclude it.
Please refer to the manual for details, and update manually.
```

2.7 Writing code to support multiple versions

In some cases, especially when writing *library* code it is desirable to support multiple LilyPond versions across breaking syntax changes. To do this alternative portions of code

can be wrapped into conditional expressions depending on the currently executed LilyPond version. The Scheme function `ly:version?` expects a comparison operator *op* and a reference version *ver* passed as a list of integers with up to three elements. Missing elements are ignored so `'(2 20)` is equivalent to *any* version of the 2.20 line of versions. Constructs like the following are possible:

```
#(cond
  ((ly:version? > '(2 20))
   (ly:message "This is code to run for LilyPond after 2.20"))
  ((ly:version? = '(2 19 57))
   (ly:message "This will only be executed with LilyPond 2.19.57"))
  (else (ly:message "This will be executed in any other version")))
```

Usually this will be integrated in library functions to allow alternative syntax to be used, but it is also possible to use the comparison directly within the music like in the following example:

```
{
  c' d' e' f'
  #(if (ly:version? = '(2 21))
      #{ \override NoteHead.color = #red #}
      #{ \override NoteHead.color = #blue #})
  g' a' b' c'
}
```

Note: This function has been introduced in LilyPond 2.21.80, so it is not possible to compare with versions earlier than that.

Footnotes

(3) Note that steps 1 and 2 must be done using the default command prompt, `cmd.exe`, and not using PowerShell!

(4) At least, this is possible in any LilyPond file that does not contain Scheme code. Otherwise the LilyPond file contains a Turing-complete language, and we run into problems with the famous “Halting Problem” in computer science.

3 Running lilypond-book

If you want to add pictures of music to a document, you can simply do it the way you would do with other types of pictures. The pictures are created separately (in PostScript, PDF, or PNG format), and those are included into a LaTeX or HTML document.

`lilypond-book` provides a way to automate this process: This program extracts snippets of music from your document, runs `lilypond` on them, and outputs the document with pictures substituted for the music. The line width and font size definitions for the music are adjusted to match the layout of your document.

This is a separate program from `lilypond` itself, and is run on the command line; for more information, see [Command-line usage](#).

This procedure may be applied to LaTeX, HTML, Texinfo or DocBook documents.

3.1 An example of a musicological document

Some texts contain music examples. These texts are musicological treatises, songbooks, or manuals like this. Such texts can be made by hand, simply by importing a PostScript or PDF figure into the word processor. However, there is an automated procedure to reduce the amount of work involved in HTML, LaTeX, Texinfo, and DocBook documents.

A script called `lilypond-book` extracts the music fragments, formats them, and puts back the resulting notation. Here we show a small example for use with LaTeX. The example also contains explanatory text, so we will not comment on it further.

Input

```
\documentclass[a4paper]{article}

\begin{document}

Documents for \verb+lilypond-book+ may freely mix music and text.
For example,

\begin{lilypond}
\relative {
  c'2 e2 \tuplet 3/2 { f8 a b } a2 e4
}
\end{lilypond}

Options to control the appearance of the snippets can be added,
too. For example,

\begin{lilypond}[fragment,quote,staffsize=26,verbatim]
  c'4 f16
\end{lilypond}
```

Larger music snippets can be put into separate files. For example,

```
\lilypondfile[quote,noindent]{screech-and-boink.ly}
```

(If needed, replace `\verb+screech-and-boink.ly+` by any `\verb+.ly+` file you put in the same directory as this file.)

```
\end{document}
```

Processing

Save the code above to a file called `lilybook.lytex`, then in a terminal run

```
> lilypond-book --output=out --pdf lilybook.lytex
lilypond-book (GNU LilyPond) 2.27.2
Reading 'lilybook.lytex'...
...lots of stuff deleted...
Writing 'out/lilybook.tex'...
> cd out
> pdflatex lilybook
This is pdfTeX, ...
(./lilybook.tex
...lots of stuff deleted...
Output written on lilypond.pdf, ...
> xpdf lilybook
(replace xpdf by your favorite PDF viewer)
```

Running `lilypond-book` and `latex` creates a lot of temporary files, which would clutter up the working directory. To remedy this, use the `--output=dir` option to create the files in a separate subdirectory `dir`.

Because this tutorial is written in Texinfo we cannot directly show the LaTeX output of the example. In the next section, however, you can see an approximation (structure-wise) of the result.

This finishes the tutorial section.

Output

Documents for lilypond-book may freely mix music and text. Using Texinfo syntax, this example

```
@lilypond
\relative {
  c'2 e2 \tuplet 3/2 { f8 a b } a2 e4
}
@end lilypond
```

produces



LilyPond v2.27.2

Options to control the appearance of snippets can be added, too. Using LaTeX syntax, this example

```
\begin{lilypond}[fragment, quote, staffsize=26]
c'4 f16
\end{lilypond}
```

produces

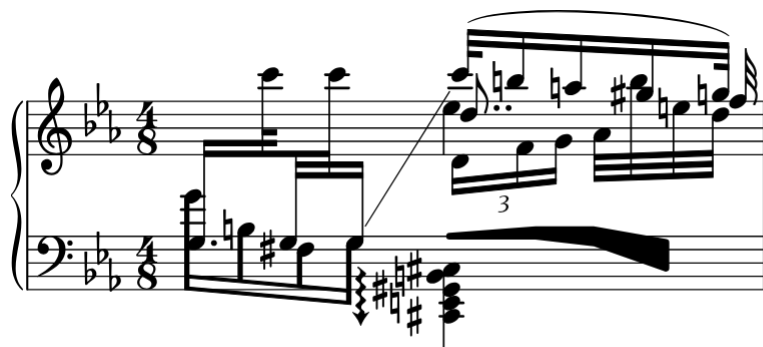


LilyPond v2.27.2

Larger music snippets can be put into separate files. Using HTML syntax, this example

```
<lilypondfile quote noindent>
  snippets/screech-and-boink.ly
</lilypondfile>
```

produces



LilyPond v2.27.2

If a tagline is required, either default or custom, the entire snippet must be enclosed in a `\book { }` construct.

```
\book {
  \header { title = "A scale in LilyPond" }

  \relative { c' d e f g a b c }
}
```

A scale in LilyPond



LilyPond v2.27.2

3.2 Integrating music and text

Here we explain in detail how to integrate LilyPond with various output formats.

3.2.1 LaTeX

LaTeX is the de-facto standard for publishing layouts in the exact sciences. It is built on top of the TeX typesetting engine, providing the best typography available anywhere.

See [The Not So Short Introduction to LaTeX](#) for an overview on how to use LaTeX.

`lilypond-book` provides the following commands and environments to include music in LaTeX files:

- the `\lilypond{...}` command to directly enter short LilyPond code,
- the `\begin{lilypond}...\end{lilypond}` environment to directly enter longer LilyPond code,
- the `\lilypondfile{...}` command to insert a LilyPond file,
- the `\musicxmlfile{...}` command to insert a MusicXML file, which gets processed by `musicxml2ly` and `lilypond`.

In the input file, music is specified with any of the following commands:

```
\begin{lilypond}[options,go,here]
  YOUR LILYPOND CODE
\end{lilypond}

\lilypond[options,go,here]{ YOUR LILYPOND CODE }

\lilypondfile[options,go,here]{filename}

\musicxmlfile[options,go,here]{filename}
```

Additionally, `\lilypondversion` displays the current version of LilyPond. Running `lilypond-book` yields a file that can be further processed with LaTeX.

We show some examples here. The `lilypond` environment

```
\begin{lilypond}[quote,fragment,staffsize=26]
  c'4 d' e' f' g'2 g'
\end{lilypond}
```

produces



LilyPond v2.27.2

The short version

```
\lilypond[quote,fragment,staffsize=11]{<c' e' g'>}
```

produces



LilyPond v2.27.2

The default line width of the music is computed by examining the commands in the document preamble (that is, the part of the document before `\begin{document}`). The `lilypond-book` command sends these to LaTeX to find out how wide the text is. The line width for music fragments is then adjusted to the text width. Note that this heuristic algorithm can fail easily; in such cases it is necessary to use the `line-width` music fragment option.

Note: Make sure that your preamble actually compiles without errors, otherwise line width detection will fail. You can test this by directly processing your document with LaTeX, using an empty `\begin{document} ... \end{document}` block. If you use a landscape paper format, be sure to add the keyword `landscape` to the option list of the `\documentclass` macro.⁵

Each snippet calls the following macros if they have been defined by the user:

-

`\preLilyPondExample` is called before the music,

-

`\postLilyPondExample` is called after the music,

-

`\betweenLilyPondSystem[1]` is called between systems if `lilypond-book` splits the snippet into several chunks. It must be defined as taking one parameter, which is the number of files already included in this snippet. The default is to simply insert `\linebreak`.

Selected snippets

Sometimes it is useful to display music elements (such as ties and slurs) as if they

continued after the end of the fragment. This can be done by breaking the staff and suppressing inclusion of the rest of the LilyPond output.

In LaTeX, define `\betweenLilyPondSystem` in such a way that inclusion of other systems is terminated once the required number of systems are included. Since `\betweenLilyPondSystem` is first called *after* the first system, including only the first system is trivial.

```
\def\betweenLilyPondSystem#1{\endinput}

\begin{lilypond}[fragment]
  c'1\(\ e'( c'\sim \break c' d) e f\ )
\end{lilypond}
```

If a greater number of systems is requested, a TeX conditional must be used before `\endinput`. In this example, replace value 2 by the number of systems you want in the output.

```
\def\betweenLilyPondSystem#1{
  \ifnum#1<2\else\expandafter\endinput\fi
}
```

(Since `\endinput` immediately stops the processing of the current input file we need `\expandafter` to delay the call of `\endinput` after executing `\fi` so that the `\if ... \fi` clause is balanced.)

Remember that the definition of `\betweenLilyPondSystem` is effective until the current group is finished (such as the LaTeX environment) or is overridden by another definition (which it is, in most cases, for the rest of the document). To reset your definition, write

```
\let\betweenLilyPondSystem\undefined
```

in your LaTeX source.

This may be simplified by defining a TeX macro

```
\def\onlyFirstNSystems#1{
  \def\betweenLilyPondSystem##1{%
    \ifnum##1<#1\else\expandafter\endinput\fi}
}
```

and then saying only how many systems you want before each fragment,

```
\onlyFirstNSystems{3}
\begin{lilypond}...\end{lilypond}
\onlyFirstNSystems{1}
\begin{lilypond}...\end{lilypond}
```

See also

There are specific `lilypond-book` command-line options and other details to know when processing LaTeX documents, see [Invoking lilypond-book](#).

3.2.2 Texinfo

Texinfo is the standard format for documentation of the GNU project. An example of a Texinfo document is this manual. The HTML, PDF, and Info versions of the manual are made from the Texinfo document.

`lilypond-book` provides the following commands and environments to include music in Texinfo files:

- the `@lilypond{...}` command to directly enter short LilyPond code,
- the `@lilypond...@end lilypond` environment to directly enter longer LilyPond code,
- the `@lilypondfile{...}` command to insert a LilyPond file,
- the `@musicxmlfile{...}` command to insert a MusicXML file, which gets processed by `musicxml2ly` and `lilypond`.

In the input file, music is specified with any of the following commands

```
@lilypond[options,go,here]
  YOUR LILYPOND CODE
@end lilypond

@lilypond[options,go,here]{ YOUR LILYPOND CODE }

@lilypondfile[options,go,here]{filename}

@musicxmlfile[options,go,here]{filename}
```

Additionally, `@lilypondversion` displays the current version of LilyPond.

The `lilypond` environment *must* start a line (possibly preceded by whitespace), even if used with the `inline fragment` option. Similarly, `@end lilypond` can be preceded by whitespace, but no text is allowed after it. If the environment has options, the opening bracket must be on the same line as the `lilypond` keyword (this does not hold for the commands that take its argument in braces). Except for this restriction, whitespace and line breaks are allowed before, in, and after the command options. Unbalanced opening or closing braces are not supported within `@lilypond{...}`.

When `lilypond-book` is run on it, this results in a Texinfo file (with extension `.texi`) containing `@image` tags for HTML, Info and printed output. `lilypond-book` generates

images of the music in EPS and PDF formats for use in the printed output, and in PNG format for use in HTML and Info output.

We show some examples here. The `lilypond` environment

```
@lilypond[quote,fragment]
  c'4 d' e' f' g'2 g'
@end lilypond
```

produces



LilyPond v2.27.2

The short version

```
@lilypond[quote,fragment,staffsize=11]{<c' e' g'>}
```

produces



LilyPond v2.27.2

See also

There are specific `lilypond-book` command-line options and other details to know when processing Texinfo documents, see [Invoking lilypond-book](#).

3.2.3 HTML

`lilypond-book` provides the following commands and environments to include music in HTML files:

- the `<lilypond ... />` command to directly enter short LilyPond code,
- the `<lilyond>...</lilyond>` environment to directly enter longer LilyPond code,
- the `<lilypondfile>...</lilypondfile>` command to insert a LilyPond file,
- the `<musicxmlfile>...</musicxmlfile>` command to insert a MusicXML file, which gets processed by `musicxml2ly` and `lilypond`.

In the input file, music is specified with any of the following commands:

```
<lilypond options go here>
```

```
YOUR LILYPOND CODE
</lilypond>

<lilypond options go here: YOUR LILYPOND CODE />

<lilypondfile options go here>filename</lilypondfile>

<musicxmlfile options go here>filename</musicxmlfile>
```

Additionally, `<lilypondversion/>` displays the current version of LilyPond.

We show some examples here. The `lilypond` environment

```
<lilypond quote fragment staffsize=26>
  c'4 d' e' f' g'2 g'
</lilypond>
```

produces



LilyPond v2.27.2

The short version

```
<lilypond quote fragment staffsize=11: <c' e' g'> />
```

produces



LilyPond v2.27.2

See also

There are specific `lilypond-book` command-line options and other details to know when processing HTML documents, see [Invoking lilypond-book](#).

3.2.4 DocBook

For inserting LilyPond snippets it is good to keep the conformity of DocBook documents, allowing the use of DocBook editors, validation, etc. For this reason no custom tags are provided, only specifying conventions based on standard DocBook elements.

Common conventions

For inserting all types of snippets we use the `mediaobject` and `inlinemediaobject` elements to format snippets inline or not inline, respectively. The snippet formatting options are always provided in the `role` property of the innermost element (see next sections). Tags are chosen to allow DocBook editors format the content gracefully. The DocBook files to be processed with `lilypond-book` should have the extension `.lyxml`.

Including a LilyPond file

This is the simplest case. We must use the `.ly` extension for the included file and insert it as a standard `imageobject`, with the following structure:

```
<mediaobject>
  <imageobject>
    <imagedata fileref="music1.ly"
      role="printfilename" />
  </imageobject>
</mediaobject>
```

Note that you can use `mediaobject` or `inlinemediaobject` as the outermost element as you wish.

Including LilyPond code

Including LilyPond code is possible by using a `programlisting` environment where the language is set to `lilypond`, with the following structure:

```
<inlinemediaobject>
  <textobject>
    <programlisting language="lilypond"
      role="fragment verbatim staffsize=16
      ragged-right relative=2">
\context Staff \with {
  \remove Time_signature_engraver
  \remove Clef_engraver}
{ c4( fis) }
    </programlisting>
  </textobject>
</inlinemediaobject>
```

As you can see, the outermost element is a `mediaobject` or `inlinemediaobject`, and there is a `textobject` containing the `programlisting` inside.

Processing the DocBook document

Running `lilypond-book` on a `.lyxml` file creates a valid DocBook document (with extension `.xml`) to be further processed. If you use [dblatex](#), it creates a PDF file from this document automatically. For HTML (HTML Help, JavaHelp, etc.) generation you can use the official DocBook XSL stylesheets; however, it is possible that you have to make some customization for it.

3.3 Music fragment options

In the following, a ‘`lilypond-book` command’ refers to any command described in the previous sections that is handled by `lilypond-book` to produce a music snippet. For simplicity, `lilypond-book` commands are only shown in Texinfo syntax (i.e., starting with ‘@’) to make them better distinguishable from LilyPond commands.

Note that the option string is parsed from left to right; if an option occurs multiple times, the last one is taken.

The following options are available for `lilypond-book` commands:

`staffsize=ht`

Set staff size to *ht*, which is measured in points.

`ragged-right`

Produce ragged-right lines with natural spacing, i.e., `ragged-right = ##t` is added to the LilyPond snippet. Single-line snippets will always be typeset by default as ragged-right, unless `noragged-right` is explicitly given.

`noragged-right`

For single-line snippets, allow the staff length to be stretched to equal that of the line width, i.e., `ragged-right = ##f` is added to the LilyPond snippet.

`line-width`

`line-width=size\unit`

Set line width to *size* (expressed in *unit*). *unit* is one of the following: `cm`, `mm`, `in`, `pt`, or `bp`. This option affects LilyPond output (that is, the staff length of the music fragment), not the text layout.

If used without an argument, or if no `line-width` option is given, `lilypond-book` tries to guess a default for `lilypond` environments that don't use the `ragged-right` option.

See also option `papersize`.

`papersize=string`

Set paper size to *string* (for example `a5` or `letter`) for music fragments that use `\book`. See Predefined paper sizes in *Notation Reference* for a list of available paper sizes.

This option affects LilyPond output (that is, the paper size of the music fragment), not the text layout. Unknown values of *string* are ignored: a warning is emitted and the snippet is printed using the document's paper size for LaTeX and Texinfo, and the A4 paper format for HTML and DocBook.

If option `papersize` is given without option `line-width` (more specifically, option `line-width` without an argument), LilyPond uses its own idea of the default line width within the snippet, also ignoring option `quote` (which still makes `lilypond-book` emit a quotation block, though).

`paper-width=size\unit`

Set paper width to *size* (expressed in *unit*) for music fragments that use `\book`. *unit* is one of the following: `cm`, `mm`, `in`, `pt`, or `bp`.

This option affects LilyPond output (that is, the paper width of the music fragment), not the text layout. If set, it overrides option `papersize` if given. If option `paper-height` is not specified, the paper height is set to the document's paper height for LaTeX and Texinfo, and the A4 paper height (296 mm) for HTML and DocBook.

paper-height=size\unit

Set paper height to *size* (expressed in *unit*) for music fragments that use `\book`. *unit* is one of the following: cm, mm, in, pt, or bp.

This option affects LilyPond output (that is, the paper height of the music fragment), not the text layout. If set, it overrides option `papersize` if given. If option `paper-width` is not specified, the paper width is set to the document's paper width for LaTeX and Texinfo, and the A4 paper width (210 mm) for HTML and DocBook.

Example:

```
\lilypond[paper-width=10\cm, paper-height=57\mm]{
  \book {
    ...
  }
}
```

notime

Do not print the time signature and turn off the timing (time signature, bar lines) in the score.

fragment

Make `lilypond-book` add some boilerplate code so that you can simply enter, say,

```
c'4
```

without `\layout`, `\score`, etc.

nofragment

Do not add additional code to complete LilyPond code in music snippets. Since this is the default, `nofragment` is redundant normally.

inline**inline=vshift**

Set up snippet for inline use, that is, to be typeset within a paragraph. The snippet itself is formatted with a very small left padding (approximately the same as the right padding), ignoring the value given by the command-line option `--left-padding`.

For the LaTeX backend, the inline image gets shifted vertically; *vshift* is a factor of the current image's height. If no argument is given a default value of `-0.3` is used, thus moving the image down by approx. one third of its height. The default value can be adjusted with command-line option `--inline-vshift`.

For Texinfo output, it suppresses the insertion of a blank line before and after the snippet. For HTML output, it suppresses the insertion of `<p>` before and `</p>` after the snippet.

To actually make a snippet appear inline in LaTeX and Texinfo mode, it is necessary to position it within a paragraph, avoiding an empty line before and after the snippet. For example, this LaTeX code

```
The motive
\lilypond[inline,staffsize=11]{
  { \time 2/4 r8 g'[ g' g'] | es'2 }
}
is widely known.
```

becomes

The motive



LilyPond v2.27.2

is widely known.

indent=size\unit

Set indentation of the first music system to *size* (expressed in *unit*). *unit* is one of the following: cm, mm, in, pt, or bp. This option affects LilyPond, not the text layout.

noindent

Set indentation of the first music system to zero. This option affects LilyPond, not the text layout. Since no indentation is the default, `noindent` is redundant normally.

quote

Reduce line length of a music snippet by 2×0.4 in and put the output into a quotation block. The value '0.4 in' can be controlled with the `exampleindent` option.

See also option `papersize`.

exampleindent

Set the amount by which the `quote` option indents a music snippet.

relative

relative=n

Use relative octave mode. By default, notes are specified relative to middle C. The optional integer argument specifies the octave of the starting note, where the default 1 is middle C. `relative` option only works when `fragment` option is set, so `fragment` is automatically implied by `relative`, regardless of the presence of any (no) `fragment` option in the source.

LilyPond also uses `lilypond-book` to produce its own documentation. To do that, some more obscure music fragment options are available.

verbatim

The argument of a `lilypond-book` command is copied to the output file and enclosed in a verbatim block, followed by any text given with the `intertext` option (not implemented yet); then the actual music is displayed. This option does not work well with `@lilypond{}` if it is part of a paragraph.

If `verbatim` is used in a `lilypondfile` command, it is possible to enclose verbatim only a part of the source file. If the source file contain a comment containing 'begin verbatim' (without quotes), quoting the source in the verbatim block will start after

the last occurrence of such a comment; similarly, quoting the source verbatim will stop just before the first occurrence of a comment containing ‘end verbatim’, if there is any. In the following source file example, the music will be interpreted in relative mode, but the verbatim quote will not show the relative block, i.e.,

```
\relative { % begin verbatim
  c'4 e2 g4
  f2 e % end verbatim
}
```

will be printed with a verbatim block like

```
c4 e2 g4
f2 e
```

If you would like to translate comments and variable names in verbatim output but not in the sources, you may set the environment variable `LYDOC_LOCALEDIR` to a directory path; the directory should contain a tree of `.mo` message catalogs with `lilypond-doc` as a domain.

texidoc

(Only for Texinfo output, and only for `@lilypondfile`.) If `lilypond` is called with the `--header=texidoc` option, and the file to be processed is called `foo.ly`, it creates a file `foo.texidoc` if there is a `texidoc` field in the `\header` block of `foo.ly`. `lilypond-book`'s `texidoc` option makes it include such a file, adding its contents as a documentation block right before the music snippet (but outside the `example` environment generated by a `quote` option).

Assuming the file `foo.ly` contains

```
\header {
  texidoc = "This file demonstrates a single note."
}
{ c'4 }
```

and we have this in our Texinfo document `test.texinfo`

```
@lilypondfile[texidoc]{foo.ly}
```

the following command line gives the expected result

```
lilypond-book --pdf \
  --process="lilypond --header=texidoc" \
  test.texinfo
```

All LilyPond documentation snippets (in the `Documentation/snippets` directory of the distribution) are `.ly` files that have such `texidoc` fields in their `\header` blocks.

For localization purposes, if the Texinfo document contains `@documentlanguage XX` and `foo.ly`'s `\header` block contains a `texidocXX` field, and if `lilypond` is called with `--`

`header=texidocXX`, then `foo.texidocXX` gets included instead of `foo.texidoc`, if present. `XX` is usually a two-letter string like ‘de’ (for German) or ‘ca’ (for Catalan).

doctitle

(Only for Texinfo output, and only for `@lilypondfile`.) This option works similarly to the `texidoc` option: if `lilypond` is called with the `--header=doctitle` option, and the file to be processed is called `foo.ly` and contains a `doctitle` field in the `\header` block, it creates a file `foo.doctitle`. When the `doctitle` option is used, the contents of `foo.doctitle`, which should be a single line of *text*, is inserted in the Texinfo document as `@lydoctitle text`. `@lydoctitle` should be a macro defined in the Texinfo document. The same remark about `texidoc` processing with localized documentation also applies to `doctitle`.

htmlprintfilename

(Only for Texinfo output.) Similar to option `printfilename`, but emit the file name for HTML output only.

nogettext

(Only for Texinfo output.) Do not translate comments and variable names in the snippet quoted verbatim.

printfilename

If an input file is included with `lilypondfile` or `musicxmlfile`, print the file name right before the music snippet. For HTML output, this is a link. Only the base name of the file is printed, i.e., the directory part of the file path is stripped.

Finally, the `musicxmlfile` command also accepts the following options, which are directly passed to `musicxml2ly`.

`absolute`, `book`, `compressed`, `dynamics-scale`, `fretboards`, `language`, `ottavas-end-early`, `no-articulation-directions`, `no-beaming`, `no-page-breaks`, `no-page-layout`, `no-page-margins`, `no-rest-positions`, `no-stem-directions`, `no-system-breaks`, `no-tagline`, `shift-duration`, `string-numbers`, `tab-clef`, `transpose`, `relative`, `verbose`

See [Invoking musicxml2ly](#) for the exact meaning of these options.

3.4 Invoking lilypond-book

`lilypond-book` produces a file with one of the following extensions: `.tex`, `.texi`, `.html` or `.xml`, depending on the output format. All of `.tex`, `.texi` and `.xml` files need further processing.

Format-specific instructions

LaTeX

There are two ways of processing your LaTeX document for printing or publishing: getting a PDF file directly with pdfLaTeX (XeLaTeX, luaLaTeX) or getting a PostScript file with LaTeX via a DVI-to-PostScript translator like `dvips`. The first way is simpler and

recommended⁶, and whichever way you use, you can easily convert between PostScript and PDF with tools, like `ps2pdf` and `pdf2ps` included in Ghostscript package.

To produce a PDF file with pdfLaTeX, use:

```
lilypond-book --pdf yourfile.lytex
pdfflatex yourfile.tex
```

To produce PDF output via LaTeX/dvips/ps2pdf:

```
lilypond-book yourfile.lytex
latex yourfile.tex
dvips -Ppdf yourfile.dvi
ps2pdf yourfile.ps
```

The `.dvi` file created by this process will not contain note heads. This is normal; if you follow the instructions, they will be included in the `.ps` and `.pdf` files.

Running `dvips` may produce some warnings about fonts; these are harmless and may be ignored. If you are running `latex` in twocolumn mode, remember to add `-t landscape` to the `dvips` options.

Environments such as

```
\begin{lilypond} ... \end{lilypond}
```

are not interpreted by LaTeX. Instead, `lilypond-book` extracts those ‘environments’ into files of its own and runs LilyPond on them. It then takes the resulting graphics and creates a `.tex` file where the `\begin{lilypond}... \end{lilypond}` macros are replaced by ‘graphics inclusion’ commands. It is at this time that LaTeX is run (although LaTeX will have run previously, it will have been, effectively, on an ‘empty’ document in order to calculate paper dimensions and the line width for LilyPond snippets).

Known issues and warnings

The `\pageBreak` command will not work within a `\begin{lilypond} ... \end{lilypond}` environment.

Many `\paper` block variables will also not work within a `\begin{lilypond} ... \end{lilypond}` environment. Use `\newcommand` with `\betweenLilyPondSystem` in the preamble.

```
\newcommand{\betweenLilyPondSystem}[1]{\vspace{36mm}\linebreak}
```

Texinfo

To produce a Texinfo document (in any output format), follow the normal procedures for Texinfo; that is, either call `texi2pdf` or `texi2dvi` or `texi2any`, depending on the output format you want to create. By default, `texi2pdf` uses `pdftex` for processing, which you can verify in the console output. In this case, run `lilypond-book` with the `--pdf` option so that

it creates .pdf snippets instead of .eps files. pdftex is unable to include the latter ones and will output an error message otherwise.

See the documentation of Texinfo for further details.

Command-line options

`lilypond-book` accepts the following command-line options.

-f *format*

--format=*format*

Specify the document type to process: `html`, `latex`, `texi` (the default), `texi-html`, or `docbook`. If this option is missing, `lilypond-book` tries to detect the format automatically, see [Filename extensions](#). Currently, `texi-html` is the same as `texi`.

-F *filter*

--filter=*filter*

Pipe snippets through *filter*. With this option, `lilypond-book` does not create snippet files; instead, it modifies the code of the embedded snippets in the input document and emits the resulting file, which in turn can then be processed by another run with `lilypond-book` (without the `--filter` option). Example:

```
lilypond-book --filter='convert-ly --from=2.0.0 -' my-book.tely
```

`lilypond-book` does not accept options `--filter` and `--process` at the same time.

-h

--help

Print a short help message.

-I *dir*

--include=*dir*

Add *dir* to the include path. Since `lilypond-book` also looks for already compiled snippets in the include path and does not write them back to the output directory, it is necessary in some cases to invoke further processing commands such as `texi2any` or `latex` with the same `-I dir` options.

-l *loglevel*

--loglevel=*loglevel*

Set the output verbosity to *loglevel*. Possible values are `NONE`, `ERROR`, `WARN`, `PROGRESS` (default), and `DEBUG`. If this option is not used and the environment variable `LILYPOND_BOOK_LOGLEVEL` is set, its value is used as the log level.

-o *dir*

--output=*dir*

Place generated files into directory *dir*. Running `lilypond-book` generates lots of small files that LilyPond will process. To avoid all that clutter in the source directory, use the

--output command-line option, and change to that directory before running latex or texi2any.

```
lilypond-book --output=out yourfile.lytex
cd out
...
```

--skip-lily-check

Do not fail if no LilyPond output is found. It is used for generating LilyPond's Info documentation without images.

--skip-png-check

Do not fail if no PNG images are found for EPS files. It is used for generating LilyPond's Info documentation without images.

--lily-output-dir=dir

Write lily-XXX files to directory *dir* and link into --output directory. Use this option to save building time for documents in different directories that share a lot of identical snippets.

--lily-loglevel=loglevel

Set the output verbosity of the invoked lilypond command to *loglevel*. Possible values are NONE, ERROR, WARN, BASIC, PROGRESS, INFO (default), and DEBUG. If this option is not used and the environment variable LILYPOND_LOGLEVEL is set, its value is used as the log level.

--info-images-dir=dir

Format Texinfo output so that Info will look for images of music in directory *dir*.

--inline-vshift=vshift

In the LaTeX backend, use *vshift* to vertically move all inline images. *vshift* is a factor of an image's height; the default value is -0.3, thus moving the images down by approx. one third of their individual heights. The factor can be locally overridden with an argument to the `inline` snippet option.

--latex-program=prog

Run executable *prog* instead of latex. This is useful if your document is processed with xelatex, for example.

--left-padding=amount

Pad LilyPond snippets on the left with whitespace.

amount is given in millimeters *relative to the start of the staff*. The default value is 3.0 mm.

The widths of tightly clipped systems can vary due to notation elements such as bar numbers or instrument names that are positioned left of the beginning of staves. The padding sets the minimum distance between the left margin of the snippet images and the beginning of (non-indented) staves; this allows the expected vertical alignment of snippets in the master document.

In addition to padding at the left, this option shortens each staff line by *amount*. As a consequence, each line is moved to the right visually.

Note that *amount*, as used for padding, is rounded up to be an integer multiple of the *big point* (bp) unit for PostScript and PDF output (one bp is 1/72th of an inch, approx. 0.353 mm). However, this is not done on the LilyPond side for shortening the staff line. This might lead to a tiny but probably surprising staff length change instead of changing the padding if *amount* is not an integer multiple of the bp unit.

-P *command*

--process=*command*

Process LilyPond snippets using *command*. The default command is `lilypond`. `lilypond-book` does not accept options `--filter` and `--process` at the same time.

--pdf

Create PDF snippet files. If not set, only PNG and EPS files are produced. Use this option if you want to directly embed PDF files into LaTeX or Texinfo files.

--redirect-lilypond-output

By default, logging output is displayed on the terminal. This option redirects all output to log files in the same directory as the source files.

--use-source-file-names

Write snippet output files with the same base name as their source file. This option works only for snippets included with the `lilypondfile` command and only if directories implied by `--output-dir` and `--lily-output-dir` options are different.

-V

--verbose

Be verbose. This is equivalent to `--loglevel=DEBUG`.

-v

--version

Print version information.

Known issues and warnings

The Texinfo command `@pagesizes` is not interpreted. Similarly, LaTeX commands that change margins and line widths after the preamble are ignored.

Only the first `\score` of a LilyPond block is processed.

3.5 Filename extensions

You can use any file name extension for the input file, but if you do not use the recommended extension for a particular format you may need to manually specify the output format; for details, see [Invoking lilypond-book](#). Otherwise, `lilypond-book` automatically selects the output format based on the input file name's extension.

extension	output format
.html	HTML
.htmly	HTML
.itely	Texinfo
.latex	LaTeX
.lytex	LaTeX
.lyxml	DocBook
.tely	Texinfo
.tex	LaTeX
.texi	Texinfo
.texinfo	Texinfo
.xml	HTML

If you use the same file name extension for the input file than the extension `lilypond-book` uses for the output file, and if the input file is in the same directory as `lilypond-book` working directory, you must use `--output` option to make `lilypond-book` running, otherwise it will exit with an error message like “Output would overwrite input file”.

3.6 Parallel execution

The `lilypond-book` script cannot be used to process documents in parallel if the output directory is the same. If you try to do so, sequential execution (in arbitrary order) of the `lilypond-book` processes is enforced instead by using a lock file.

In other words, to process documents `foo.lytex` and `bar.lytex` at the same time (via the `make` utility, for example), put them either into two different directories, say, `foo/foo.lytex` and `bar/bar.lytex`, or use command-line option `--output` with different values.

Note that LilyPond itself can process multiple input files in parallel, actually. Since `lilypond-book` passes a list of all snippets in a document to `lilypond` in one rush, parallel execution is possible by using its `-djob-count` option.

```
lilypond-book --process="lilypond -djob-count=4" \
  --output=foo \
  ... \
  foo.lytex
```

3.7 lilypond-book templates

These templates are for use with lilypond-book. If you're not familiar with this program, please refer to [lilypond-book](#).

LaTeX

You can include LilyPond fragments in a LaTeX document.

```
\documentclass{article}

% here you can insert packages all LaTeX flavours understand
\usepackage[ngerman,finnish,english]{babel}
\usepackage{graphicx}
\usepackage{libertinus}

\usepackage{iftex}
\ifxetex
  % stuff specific to XeTeX
  \usepackage{xltextra}
\else
  % this can be empty if you are not going to use pdfTeX
  \usepackage[T1]{fontenc}
\fi

\begin{document}

\title{A short document with LilyPond and \LaTeX}
\maketitle

Normal \textbf{font} commands inside the \emph{text} work,
because they are \textsf{supported} by all \LaTeX{} flavours}.
If you want to use specific commands like \verb+\XeTeX+, you
should include them again in a \verb+\ifxetex+ block.
You can use this to print the \ifxetex \XeTeX{} \else XeTeX \fi
command, which is not known to pdfTeX by default.

In normal text you can easily use LilyPond commands, like this:

\smallskip
\begin[staffsize=12]{lilypond}
{ a2^"foo" b_"bar" c'8 c' c' c' }

\paper {
  property-defaults.fonts.serif = "Libertinus Serif"
}
\end{lilypond}
\smallskip

\noindent
Note that the fonts used in snippets have to be set from inside
the snippets, as demonstrated.

\selectlanguage{ngerman}
```

Da die Standard-Eingabekodierung von `\LaTeX{}` UTF-8 ist, funktionieren Umlaute u.\,ä. ohne `\LaTeX`-Akzentbefehle (ßäöü), wenn sie von der Schriftart unterstützt werden.

```
\end{document}
```

Texinfo

You can include LilyPond fragments in Texinfo; in fact, this entire manual is written in Texinfo.

```
\input texinfo

@ifnottex
@node Top
@top
@end ifnottex

Texinfo text

@lilypond
\relative {
  a4 b c d
}
@end lilypond

More Texinfo text, and options in brackets.

@lilypond[verbatim,fragment,ragged-right]
d4 c b a
@end lilypond

@bye
```

HTML

```
<!DOCTYPE HTML PUBLIC "-//W3C//DTD HTML 4.01 Transitional//EN">
<HTML>
<body>

<p>
Documents for lilypond-book may freely mix music and text. For
example,
<lilypond>
\relative {
  a'4 b c d
}
</lilypond>
</p>

<p>
Another bit of lilypond, this time with options:

<lilypond fragment quote staffsize=26 verbatim>
a4 b c d
```



```

</lilypond>
</p>

</body>
</html>

```

3.8 Sharing the table of contents

These functions already exist in the `OrchestralLily` package:

<https://repo.or.cz/w/orchestrallily.git>

For greater flexibility in text handling, some users prefer to export the table of contents from `lilypond` and read it into LaTeX.

Exporting the ToC from LilyPond

This assumes that your score has multiple movements in the same `lilypond` output file.

```

#(define (oly:create-toc-file layout pages)
  (let* ((label-table (ly:output-def-lookup layout 'label-page-table)))
    (if (not (null? label-table))
      (let* ((format-line (lambda (toc-item)
                            (let* ((label (car toc-item))
                                   (text (caddr toc-item))
                                   (label-page (and (list? label-table)
                                                    (assoc label label-table)))
                                   (page (and label-page (cdr label-page))))
                              (format #f "~a, section, 1, {~a}, ~a" page text label))))
            (formatted-toc-items (map format-line (toc-items)))
            (whole-string (string-join formatted-toc-items ",\n"))
            (output-name (ly:parser-output-name))
            (outfilename (format #f "~a.toc" output-name))
            (outfile (open-output-file outfilename)))
        (if (output-port? outfile)
            (display whole-string outfile)
            (ly:warning (G_ "Unable to open output file ~a for the TOC information")
                        outfilename))
        (close-output-port outfile))))))

\paper {
  #(define (page-post-process layout pages) (oly:create-toc-file layout pages))
}

```

Importing the ToC into LaTeX

In LaTeX, the header should include:

```

\usepackage{pdfpages}
\includescore{nameofthescore}

```

where `\includescore` is defined as:

```

%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%
% \includescore{PossibleExtension}
%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%%

% Read in the TOC entries for a PDF file from the corresponding .toc file.

```

```
% This requires some heave latex tweaking, since reading in things from a file
% and inserting it into the arguments of a macro is not (easily) possible

% Solution by Patrick Fimml on #latex on April 18, 2009:
% \readfile{filename}{\variable}
% reads in the contents of the file into \variable (undefined if file
% doesn't exist)
\newread\readfile@f
\def\readfile@line#1{%
{\catcode`\^^M=10\global\read\readfile@f to \readfile@tmp}%
\edef\do{\noexpand\g@addto@macro{\noexpand#1}{\readfile@tmp}}\do%
\ifeof\readfile@f\else%
\readfile@line{#1}%
\fi%
}
\def\readfile#1#2{%
\openin\readfile@f=#1 %
\ifeof\readfile@f%
\typeout{No TOC file #1 available!}%
\else%
\gdef#2{}%
\readfile@line{#2}%
\fi
\closein\readfile@f%
}%

\newcommand{\includescore}[1]{
\def\oly@fname{\oly@basename@ifmtarg{#1}{}{\_#1}}
\let\oly@addtotoc\undefined
\readfile{\oly@xxxxxxxx}{\oly@addtotoc}
\ifx\oly@addtotoc\undefined
\includepdf[pages=-]{\oly@fname}
\else
\edef\includeit{\noexpand\includepdf[pages=-, addtotoc={\oly@addtotoc}]
{\oly@fname}}\includeit
\fi
}
```

3.9 Alternative methods of mixing text and music

Other means of mixing text and music (without `lilypond-book`) are discussed in [LilyPond output in other programs](#).

Footnotes

(5) This is necessary because `lilypond-book` adds `\usepackage{graphics}` to the preamble if neither the `graphics` nor the `graphicx` package gets loaded; this might change the paper dimensions unexpectedly for some document classes.

(6) Note that pdfLaTeX and LaTeX may not be both usable to compile any LaTeX document, that is why we explain the two ways.

4 External programs

LilyPond can interact with other programs in various ways.

4.1 Point and click

Point and click lets you find notes in the input by clicking on them in the PDF viewer. This makes it easier to find input that causes some error in the sheet music.

4.1.1 Configuring the system

When this functionality is active, LilyPond adds hyperlinks to PDF and SVG files. These hyperlinks are sent to a ‘URI helper’ or a web-browser, which opens a text-editor with the cursor in the right place.

To make this chain work, you should configure your PDF viewer to follow hyperlinks using the `lilypond-invoke-editor` script supplied with LilyPond.

The program `lilypond-invoke-editor` is a small helper program. It will invoke an editor for the special `textedit` URIs, and run a web browser for others. It looks up the environment variables `EDITOR` and `LYEDITOR` to find out and launch the favorite editor to use. `LYEDITOR` will have priority over `EDITOR`, so we recommend using the former especially if you want to use one editor in the terminal and another editor for LilyPond point and click.

Every editor may have a different syntax to open a file in a specific line and column. For user’s convenience, LilyPond comes with ready commands for several editors, listed in `scripts/lilypond-invoke-editor.py`. This means that you can simply write the editor binary name, e.g.:

```
export LYEDITOR=atom
```

and this will invoke

```
atom %(file)s:%(line)s:%(column)s
```

where `%(file)s`, `%(line)s` and `%(column)s` are replaced with the file, line and column respectively.

In order to use an editor not listed in the script, you should find its specific syntax and assign the full command to `LYEDITOR`. Here’s an example for Visual Studio Code editor:

```
export LYEDITOR="code --goto %(file)s:%(line)s:%(column)s"
```

Note: If you choose Emacs, an extra configuration is needed. You should add the line `(server-start)` to your `~/.emacs` file, otherwise every click on an object in the PDF will open a new Emacs window.

Using GNOME

In GNOME, URIs are handled via ‘.desktop’ files. Create a file in a local directory such as /tmp that is called `lilypond-invoke-editor.desktop` and has the contents;

```
[Desktop Entry]
Version=1.0
Name=lilypond-invoke-editor
GenericName=Textedit URI handler
Comment=URI handler for textedit:
Exec=lilypond-invoke-editor %u
Terminal=false
Type=Application
MimeType=x-scheme-handler/textedit;
Categories=Editor
NoDisplay=true
```

and then execute the commands

```
xdg-desktop-menu install ./lilypond-invoke-editor.desktop
xdg-mime default lilypond-invoke-editor.desktop x-scheme-handler/textedit
```

After that invocation;

```
xdg-open textedit:///etc/issue:1:0:0
```

should call `lilypond-invoke-editor` for opening files.

Extra configuration for Evince

If `xdg-open` works, but Evince still refuses to open point and click links due to denied permissions, you might need to change the Apparmor profile of Evince which controls the kind of actions Evince is allowed to perform.

For Ubuntu, the process is to edit the file `/etc/apparmor.d/local/usr.bin.evince` and append the following lines:

```
# For Textedit links
/usr/local/bin/lilypond-invoke-editor Cx -> sanitized_helper,
```

After adding these lines, call

```
sudo apparmor_parser -r -T -W /etc/apparmor.d/usr.bin.evince
```

Now Evince should be able to open point and click links. It is likely that similar configurations will work for other viewers.

Enabling point and click

Point and click functionality is enabled by default when creating PDF or SVG files.

The point and click links enlarge the output files significantly. For reducing the size of these (and PS) files, point and click may be switched off by issuing

```
\pointAndClickOff
```

in a .ly file. Point and click may be explicitly enabled with

```
\pointAndClickOn
```

Alternately, you may disable point and click with a command-line option:

```
lilypond -dno-point-and-click file.ly
```

Note: You should always turn off point and click in any LilyPond files to be distributed to avoid including path information about your computer in the PDF file, which can pose a security risk.

Selective point-and-click

For some interactive applications, it may be desirable to only include certain point-and-click items. For example, if somebody wanted to create an application which played audio or video starting from a particular note, it would be awkward if clicking on the note produced the point-and-click location for an accidental or slur which occurred over that note.

This may be controlled by indicating which events to include:

-

Hard-coded in the .ly file:

```
\pointAndClickTypes #'note-event
\relative {
  c'2\f( f)
}
```

or

```
#{ly:set-option 'point-and-click 'note-event)
\relative {
  c'2\f( f)
}
```

-

Command line:

```
lilypond -dpoint-and-click=note-event example.ly
```

Multiple events can be included:

-

Hard-coded in the .ly file:

```
\pointAndClickTypes #'(note-event dynamic-event)
\relative {
  c'2\f( f)
}
```

or

```
#{ly:set-option 'point-and-click '(note-event dynamic-event))
\relative {
  c'2\f( f)
}
```

•

Command line:

```
lilypond \
  -dpoint-and-click="(note-event dynamic-event)" \
  example.ly
```

4.2 Text editor support

There is support for different text editors for LilyPond.

Emacs mode

Emacs has a `lilypond-mode`, which provides keyword autocompletion, indentation, LilyPond specific parenthesis matching and syntax coloring, handy compile short-cuts and reading LilyPond manuals using Info. If `lilypond-mode` is not installed on your platform, see below.

An Emacs mode for entering music and running LilyPond is contained in the source archive in the `elisp` directory. Do make `install` to install it to `elispdir`. The file `lilypond-init.el` should be placed to `load-path/site-start.d/` or appended to your `~/.emacs` or `~/.emacs.el`.

As a user, you may want add your source path (e.g. `~/site-lisp/`) to your `load-path` by appending the following line (as modified) to your `~/.emacs`

```
(setq load-path
      (append (list (expand-file-name "~/site-lisp")) load-path))
```

Vim mode

For [Vim](#), a filetype plugin, indent mode, and syntax-highlighting mode are available to use with LilyPond. To enable all of these features, create (or modify) your `$HOME/.vimrc` to contain these three lines, in order:

```
filetype off
set runtimepath+="/usr/local/share/lilypond/2.27.2/vim/"
filetype on
```

```
syntax on
```

If LilyPond is not installed in the `/usr/local/` directory, change the path appropriately. This topic is discussed in Other sources of information in *Learning Manual*.

Other editors

Other editors (both text and graphical) support LilyPond, but their special configuration files are not distributed with LilyPond. Consult their documentation for more information. Such editors are listed in Easier editing in *General Information*.

4.3 Converting from other formats

Music can be entered also by importing it from other formats. This chapter documents the tools included in the distribution to do so. There are other tools that produce LilyPond input, for example GUI sequencers and XML converters. Refer to the [website](#) for more details.

These are separate programs from `lilypond` itself, and are run on the command line; see [Command-line usage](#) for more information.

Known issues and warnings

We unfortunately do not have the resources to maintain these programs; please consider them “as-is”. Patches are appreciated, but bug reports will almost certainly not be resolved.

4.3.1 Invoking `midi2ly`

`midi2ly` translates a Type 1 MIDI file to a LilyPond source file.

MIDI (Music Instrument Digital Interface) is a standard for digital instruments: it specifies cabling, a serial protocol and a file format. The MIDI file format is a de facto standard format for exporting music from other programs, so this capability may come in useful when importing files from a program that has a converter for a direct format.

`midi2ly` converts tracks into Staff in *Internals Reference* and channels into Voice in *Internals Reference* contexts. Relative mode is used for pitches, durations are only written when necessary.

It is possible to record a MIDI file using a digital keyboard, and then convert it to `.ly`. However, human players are not rhythmically exact enough to make a MIDI to LY conversion trivial. When invoked with quantizing (`-s` and `-d` options) `midi2ly` tries to compensate for these timing errors, but is not very good at this. It is therefore not recommended to use `midi2ly` for human-generated midi files.

It is invoked from the command line as follows,

```
midi2ly [option]... midi-file
```

Note that by ‘command line’, we mean the command line of the operating system. See [Converting from other formats](#), for more information about this.

The following options are supported by `mid2ly`.

- a, --absolute-pitches**
Print absolute pitches.
- d, --duration-quant=DUR**
Quantize note durations on *DUR*.
- e, --explicit-durations**
Print explicit durations.
- h, --help**
Show summary of usage.
- k, --key=acc[:minor]**
Set default key. *acc* > 0 sets number of sharps; *acc* < 0 sets number of flats. A minor key is indicated by :1.
- o, --output=file**
Write output to *file*.
- s, --start-quant=DUR**
Quantize note starts on *DUR*.
- t, --allow-tuplet=DUR*NUM/DEN**
Allow tuplet durations *DUR*NUM/DEN*.
- v, --verbose**
Be verbose.
- V, --version**
Print version number.
- w, --warranty**
Show warranty and copyright.
- x, --text-lyrics**
Treat every text as a lyric.

Known issues and warnings

Overlapping notes in an arpeggio will not be correctly rendered. The first note will be read and the others will be ignored. Set them all to a single duration and add phrase markings or pedal indicators.

4.3.2 Invoking `musicxml2ly`

[MusicXML](#) is an XML dialect for representing music notation. It is the de-facto standard for interchanging scores between notation programs. However, some of its elements are

rather low-level and graphic-oriented, which makes it non-trivial (and sometimes even impossible) to automatically convert them to LilyPond.

The Python script `musicxml2ly` extracts notes, articulations, score structure, and lyrics from ‘part-wise’ MusicXML files, writing them to a `.ly` file. It is run from the command line as follows.

```
musicxml2ly [option]... file
```

Note that by ‘command line’ we mean the command line of the operating system. See [Converting from other formats](#), for more information about this.

By default, `musicxml2ly` strips off the extension from *file* and appends `.ly` to construct the output file name. If *file* is ‘-’, the script reads from standard input (and writes to standard output) instead.

If the file called *file* cannot be found, *file.xml*, *file.musicxml*, and *file.mxl* are also tried as input files.

The following options are supported by `musicxml2ly`.

-a, --absolute

Convert pitches in absolute mode.

--book

Put the top-level score into a `\book { ... }` block. This might be useful for further processing with `lilypond-book`.

--cp, --credit-page=*n*

Specify the page from which LilyPond should take `<credit>` data to fill the `\header` block. To suppress the handling of `<credit>` elements, pass value 0. The default value is 1, i.e., take the data from the first page.

--ds, --dynamics-scale=*factor*

Scale `<dynamics>` elements by a non-negative *factor*; value 0 means to use LilyPond’s standard size for dynamics. This option might be needed for MusicXML files that use a music font like ‘Maestro’, where the size of dynamics symbols like ‘f’ or ‘p’ differ greatly from LilyPond’s ‘Emmentaler’ glyphs.

--fb --fretboards

Convert `<frame>` events to a separate FretBoard voice instead of markups.

-h, --help

Print usage information and a summary of all the available command-line options.

-l, --language=*lang*

Use *lang* for pitch names, e.g., `deutsch` for note names in German. Allowed values are the note input languages supported by LilyPond, see Note names in other languages in *Notation Reference*.

--loglevel=*log-level*

Set the output verbosity to *log-level*. Possible values are NONE, ERROR, WARN, PROGRESS (which is the default), and DEBUG.

-m, --midi

Activate the MIDI block in the output LilyPond file.

--nb, --no-beaming

Do not convert beaming information, use LilyPond's automatic beaming instead.

--nd, --no-articulation-directions

Do not convert directions ('^', '_', or '-') for articulations, dynamics, etc.

--npb, --no-page-breaks

Ignore page breaks.

--npl, --no-page-layout

Do not convert the exact page layout and breaks. This is a shortcut for options --npb, --npm, and --nsb.

--npm, --no-page-margins

Ignore page margins.

--nrp, --no-rest-positions

Do not convert exact vertical position of rests.

--nsb, --no-system-breaks

Ignore system breaks.

--nsd, --no-stem-directions

Ignore stem directions given in the MusicXML file, use LilyPond's automatic stemming instead.

--nt, --no-tagline

Don't emit a LilyPond tagline (at the bottom of the last page).

-o, --output=file

Set the output file name to *file*. If *file* is '-', the output will be printed to standard output.

--oe, --ottavas-end-early=t[rue]/f[alse]

Expect <octave-shift> end elements before the associated <note> (as in the 'Finale' notation software) if value is 't' (or true). Default is 'f' (or false).

-r, --relative

Convert pitches in relative mode (this option is set by default).

--sm, --shift-duration=value

Shift durations and time signatures by *value*; for example, value -1 doubles all durations, and value 1 halves them.

--sn --string-numbers=t[rue]/f[alse]

Control output of string numbers; value 'f' (or `false`) disables them. Default is 't' (or `true`).

--tc, --tab-clef=*tab-clef-name*

Switch between two versions of tab clefs. Possible values for *tab-clef-name* are `tab` (the default) and `moderntab`.

--transpose=*to-pitch*

Set pitch to transpose by the interval between pitch 'c' and *to-pitch*.

-v, --verbose

Be verbose.

--version

Show version number and exit.

-z, --compressed

Input file is a compressed MusicXML file. By default, this option is active if the input file has `.mxl` as the extension.

4.3.3 Invoking `abc2ly`

Note: This is not currently supported and may eventually be removed from future versions of LilyPond.

ABC is a fairly simple ASCII based format. It is described at the ABC site:

<http://www.walshaw.plus.com/abc/learn.html>.

`abc2ly` translates from ABC to LilyPond. It is invoked as follows:

```
abc2ly [option]... abc-file
```

The following options are supported by `abc2ly`:

-b, --beams=None

preserve ABC's notion of beams

-h, --help

this help

-o, --output=*file*

set output file name to *file*.

-s, --strict

be strict about success

--version

print version information.

There is a rudimentary facility for adding LilyPond code to the ABC source file. For example;

```
%%LY voices \set autoBeaming = ##f
```

This will cause the text following the keyword ‘voices’ to be inserted into the current voice of the LilyPond output file.

Similarly,

```
%%LY slyrics more words
```

will cause the text following the ‘slyrics’ keyword to be inserted into the current line of lyrics.

Known issues and warnings

The ABC standard is not very ‘standard’. For extended features (e.g., polyphonic music) different conventions exist.

Multiple tunes in one file cannot be converted.

ABC synchronizes words and notes at the beginning of a line; abc2ly does not.

abc2ly ignores the ABC beaming.

4.3.4 Invoking etf2ly

Note: This is not currently supported and may eventually be removed from future versions of LilyPond.

ETF (Enigma Transport Format) is a format used by Coda Music Technology’s Finale product. etf2ly will convert part of an ETF file to a ready-to-use LilyPond file.

It is invoked from the command line as follows;

```
etf2ly [option]... etf-file
```

Note that by ‘command line’, we mean the command line of the operating system. See [Converting from other formats](#), for more information about this.

The following options are supported by etf2ly:

-h, --help

this help

-o, --output=FILE

set output file name to FILE

--version

version information

Known issues and warnings

The list of articulation scripts is incomplete. Empty measures confuse `etf2ly`. Sequences of grace notes are ended improperly.

4.3.5 Other formats

LilyPond itself does not come with support for any other formats, but some external tools can also generate LilyPond files. These are listed in Easier editing in *General Information*.

4.4 LilyPond output in other programs

This section shows methods to integrate text and music, different than the automated method with `lilypond-book`.

4.4.1 LuaTeX

As well as `lilypond-book` to integrate LilyPond output, there is an alternative program that can be used when using LuaTeX called [lyluatex](#).

4.4.2 OpenOffice and LibreOffice

LilyPond notation can be added to OpenOffice.org and LibreOffice with [OOoLilyPond](#), an OpenOffice.org extension that converts LilyPond files into images within OpenOffice.org documents. OOoLilyPond (OLy) works with recent versions of LibreOffice and OpenOffice. Older versions should work as well. It has even been tested with OpenOffice 2.4 without issues.

4.4.3 ly2video

Using the Python script [ly2video](#) it is possible to create videos that contain a horizontally scrolling score synchronized with a MIDI-generated audio rendering of the music. It is also possible to synchronize the video of the scrolling music notation with a previously recorded audio track of the same music, such as a live performance, even if the audio uses *tempo rubato* or is not precisely metronomic.

4.4.4 Other programs

When integrating LilyPond scores into documents in other software, you have to effectively mimic how `lilypond-book` runs `lilypond`.

Here we discuss how to create PNG images for use with online formats similar to HTML, and PDF and EPS for print-out formats similar to PDF.

PDF documents are usually formatted to enable printing. This means that long pieces of music must be distributed over several pages. For this mode of operation, invoke `lilypond` as

```
lilypond -dseparate-page-formats=pdf myfile.ly
```

This creates `myfile-1.pdf`, `myfile-2.pdf`, ..., each containing a single page.

For embedding the images in a PostScript file, you can create EPS files, using `-dseparate-page-formats=eps`. In this case, you may also want to specify `-dno-gs-load-fonts` and `-dinclude-eps-fonts`, otherwise the EPS files will not render if they are copied to another computer.

HTML documents are not printed, so they usually don't have to worry about splitting music images across page breaks, and you can use a single (possibly very tall) image to represent a long score. This can be achieved with

```
lilypond -dtall-page-formats=png myfile.ly
```

yielding a `myfile.png` that has all the pages of `myfile.ly` stacked vertically.

Specifying either `-dseparate-page-formats` or `-dtall-page-formats` suppresses the standard output mode (single file with multiple pages) and the associated `--formats` option. Both options take a comma-separated list of formats and can be specified together, e.g.

```
lilypond -dseparate-page-formats=eps,pdf \
        -dtall-page-formats=png,svg \
        myfile.ly
```

To reduce the margins around the pages pass the `-dno-use-paper-size-for-page` option to crop extraneous whitespace. The following paper settings will elide page numbers and other footers that enlarge the page.

```
\paper{
  indent=0\mm
  oddFooterMarkup=##f
  oddHeaderMarkup=##f
  bookTitleMarkup = ##f
  scoreTitleMarkup = ##f
}

... music ...
```

The above discusses how pages are dumped into output files, but for music integrated into text, you often don't want full pages (possibly including page numbers, margins etc.), but rather lines of music. This is achieved by including `lilypond-book-preamble.ly` before a fragment of music. This makes a toplevel `\score` block render into lines of music rather than pages.

If you need to quote many fragments from a large score, you can also use the clip systems feature, see *Extracting fragments of music in Notation Reference*.

4.5 Independent includes

Some users have produced files that can be `\included` with LilyPond to produce certain effects and those listed below are part of the LilyPond distribution. Also see *Working with input files* in *Notation Reference*.

4.5.1 MIDI articulation

The [Articulate](#) project is an attempt to enhance LilyPond's MIDI output and works by adjusting note lengths (that are not under slurs) according to the articulation markings attached to them. For example, a 'staccato' halves the note value, 'tenuto' gives a note its full duration and so on. See *Enhancing MIDI output* in *Notation Reference*.

5 Suggestions for writing files

Now you're ready to begin writing larger LilyPond input files – not just the little examples in the tutorial, but whole pieces. But how should you go about doing it?

As long as LilyPond can understand your input files and produce the output that you want, it doesn't matter what your input files look like. However, there are a few other things to consider when writing LilyPond input files.

-

What if you make a mistake? The structure of a LilyPond file can make certain errors easier (or harder) to find.

-

What if you want to share your input files with somebody else? In fact, what if you want to alter your own input files in a few years? Some LilyPond input files are understandable at first glance; others may leave you scratching your head for an hour.

-

What if you want to upgrade your LilyPond file for use with a later version of LilyPond? The input syntax changes occasionally as LilyPond improves. Most changes can be done automatically with `convert-ly`, but some changes might require manual assistance. LilyPond input files can be structured in order to be easier (or harder) to update.

5.1 General suggestions

Here are a few suggestions that can help to avoid (and fix) the most common problems when typesetting:

-

Always include a `\version` number in your input files no matter how small they are. This prevents having to remember which version of LilyPond the file was created with and is especially relevant when [Updating files with `convert-ly`](#) command (which requires the `\version` statement to be present); or if sending your input files to other users (e.g., when asking for help on the mail lists). Note that all of the LilyPond templates contain `\version` numbers.

-

For each line in your input file, write one bar of music. This will make debugging any problems in your input files much simpler.

-

Include bar checks, bar number checks, as well as octave checks (see Bar and bar number checks in *Notation Reference* and Octave checks in *Notation Reference*).

Including ‘checks’ of this type in your input files will help pinpoint mistakes more quickly. How often checks are added will depend on the complexity of the music being typeset. For simple compositions, checks added at a few at strategic points within the music can be enough but for more complex music, with many voices and/or staves, checks may be better placed after every bar.

.

Add comments within input files. References to musical themes (i.e. ‘second theme in violins’, ‘fourth variation,’ etc.), or simply including bar numbers as comments, will make navigating the input file much simpler especially if something needs to be altered later on or if passing on LilyPond input files to another person.

.

Add explicit note durations at the start of ‘sections’. For example, c4 d e f instead of just c d e f can make rearranging the music later on simpler.

.

Learn to indent and align braces and parallel music. Many problems are often caused by either ‘missing’ braces. Clearly indenting ‘opening’ and ‘closing’ braces (or << and >> indicators) will help avoid such problems. For example;

```
\new Staff {
  \relative {
    r4 g'8 g c8 c4 d |
    e4 r8 |
    % Ossia section
    <<
      { f8 c c | }
      \new Staff {
        f8 f c |
      }
    >>
    r4 |
  }
}
```

is much easier to follow than;

```
\new Staff { \relative { r4 g'8 g c4 c8 d | e4 r8
% Ossia section
<< { f8 c c } \new Staff { f8 f c } >> r4 | } }
```

.

Keep music and style separate by putting overrides in the \layout block;

```
\score {
  ...music...
  \layout {
    \override TabStaff.Stemstencil = ##f
  }
}
```

```
}
```

This will not create a new context but it will apply when one is created. Also see Saving typing with variables and functions in *Learning Manual*, and Style sheets in *Learning Manual*.

5.2 Typesetting existing music

If you are entering music from an existing score (i.e., typesetting a piece of existing sheet music),

-

Enter the manuscript (the physical copy of the music) into LilyPond one system at a time (but still only one bar per line of text), and check each system when you finish it. You may use the `showLastLength` or `showFirstLength` properties to speed up processing – see Skipping corrected music in *Notation Reference*.

-

Define `mBreak = { \break }` and insert `\mBreak` in the input file whenever the manuscript has a line break. This makes it much easier to compare the LilyPond music to the original music. When you are finished proofreading your score, you may define `mBreak = { }` to remove all those line breaks. This will allow LilyPond to place line breaks wherever it feels are best.

-

When entering a part for a transposing instrument into a variable, it is recommended that the notes are wrapped in

```
\transpose c natural-pitch {...}
```

(where `natural-pitch` is the open pitch of the instrument) so that the music in the variable is effectively in C. You can transpose it back again when the variable is used, if required, but you might not want to (e.g., when printing a score in concert pitch, converting a trombone part from treble to bass clef, etc.). Mistakes in transpositions are less likely if all the music in variables is at a consistent pitch.

Also, only ever transpose to/from C. That means that the only other keys you will use are the natural pitches of the instruments – `bes` for a B-flat trumpet, `aes` for an A-flat clarinet, etc.

5.3 Large projects

When working on a large project, having a clear structure to your lilypond input files becomes vital.

-

Use a variable for each voice, with a minimum of structure inside the definition. The structure of the `\score` section is the most likely thing to change; the `violin` definition is extremely unlikely to change in a new version of LilyPond.

```
violin = \relative {
  g'4 c'8. e16
}
...
\score {
  \new GrandStaff {
    \new Staff {
      \violin
    }
  }
}
```

Separate tweaks from music definitions. This point was made previously, but for large projects it is absolutely vital. We might need to change the definition of `fthenp`, but then we only need to do this once, and we can still avoid touching anything inside `violin`.

```
fthenp = _\markup{
  \dynamic f \italic \small { 2nd } \hspace #0.1 \dynamic p }

violin = \relative {
  g'4\fthenp c'8. e16
}
```

5.4 Troubleshooting

Sooner or later, you will write a file that LilyPond cannot compile. The messages that LilyPond gives may help you find the error, but in many cases you need to do some investigation to determine the source of the problem.

The most powerful tools for this purpose are the single line comment (indicated by `%`) and the block comment (indicated by `%{...%}`). If you don't know where a problem is, start commenting out huge portions of your input file. After you comment out a section, try compiling the file again. If it works, then the problem must exist in the portion you just commented. If it doesn't work, then keep on commenting out material until you have something that works.

In an extreme case, you might end up with only

```
\score {
  <<
    % \melody
    % \harmony
    % \bass
  >>
```

```
\layout{}
}
```

(in other words, a file without any music)

If that happens, don't give up. Uncomment a bit – say, the bass part – and see if it works. If it doesn't work, then comment out all of the bass music (but leave `\bass` in the `\score` uncommented).

```
bass = \relative {
%{
  c'4 c c c
  d d d d
%}
}
```

Now start slowly uncommenting more and more of the bass part until you find the problem line.

Another very useful debugging technique is constructing Tiny examples in *General Information*.

5.5 Make and Makefiles

Pretty well all the platforms LilyPond can run on support a software facility called `make`. This software reads a special file called a `Makefile` that defines what files depend on what others and what commands you need to give the operating system to produce one file from another. For example the makefile would spell out how to produce `ballad.pdf` and `ballad.midi` from `ballad.ly` by running LilyPond.

There are times when it is a good idea to create a `Makefile` for your project, either for your own convenience or as a courtesy to others who might have access to your source files. This is true for very large projects with many included files and different output options (e.g., full score, parts, conductor's score, piano reduction, etc.), or for projects that require difficult commands to build them (such as `lilypond-book` projects). Makefiles vary greatly in complexity and flexibility, according to the needs and skills of the authors. The program GNU Make comes installed on GNU/Linux distributions and on macOS, and it is also available for Windows.

See the **GNU Make Manual** for full details on using `make`, as what follows here gives only a glimpse of what it can do.

The commands to define rules in a makefile differ according to platform; for instance the various forms of GNU/Linux and macOS use `bash`, while Windows uses `cmd`. Note that on macOS, you need to configure the system to use the command-line interpreter. Here are some example makefiles, with versions for both GNU/Linux/macOS and Windows.

The first example is for an orchestral work in four movements with a directory structure as follows:

```

Symphony/
|-- MIDI/
|-- Makefile
|-- Notes/
| |-- cello.ily
| |-- figures.ily
| |-- horn.ily
| |-- oboe.ily
| |-- trioString.ily
| |-- viola.ily
| |-- violinOne.ily
| `-- violinTwo.ily
|-- PDF/
|-- Parts/
| |-- symphony-cello.ly
| |-- symphony-horn.ly
| |-- symphony-oboe.ly
| |-- symphony-violin.ly
| |-- symphony-violinOne.ly
| `-- symphony-violinTwo.ly
|-- Scores/
| |-- symphony.ly
| |-- symphonyI.ly
| |-- symphonyII.ly
| |-- symphonyIII.ly
| `-- symphonyIV.ly
`-- symphonyDefs.ily

```

The .ly files in the Scores and Parts directories get their notes from .ily files in the Notes directory:

```

%% top of file "symphony-cello.ly"
\include "../symphonyDefs.ily"
\include "../Notes/cello.ily"

```

The makefile will have targets of score (entire piece in full score), movements (individual movements in full score), and parts (individual parts for performers). There is also a target archive that will create a tarball of the source files, suitable for sharing via web or email. Here is the makefile for GNU/Linux or macOS. It should be saved with the name Makefile in the top directory of the project:

Note: When a target or pattern rule is defined, the subsequent lines must begin with tabs, not spaces.

```

# the name stem of the output files
piece := symphony
# The command to run lilypond
LILY_CMD := lilypond -ddelete-intermediate-files \
             -dno-point-and-click

# The suffixes used in this Makefile.
.SUFFIXES: .ly .ily .pdf .midi

```

```

.DEFAULT_GOAL := score

PDFDIR := PDF
MIDIDIR := MIDI

# Input and output files are searched in the directories listed in
# the VPATH variable. All of them are subdirectories of the current
# directory (given by the GNU make variable `CURDIR`).
VPATH := \
    $(CURDIR)/Scores \
    $(CURDIR)/Parts \
    $(CURDIR)/Notes \
    $(CURDIR)/$(PDFDIR) \
    $(CURDIR)/$(MIDIDIR)

# The pattern rule to create PDF and MIDI files from a LY input file.
# The .pdf output files are put into the `PDF` subdirectory, and the
# .midi files go into the `MIDI` subdirectory.
%.pdf %.midi: %.ly | $(PDFDIR) $(MIDIDIR)
    $(LILY_CMD) $< # this line begins with a tab
    mv "$*.pdf" $(PDFDIR)/ # this line begins with a tab
    mv "$*.midi" $(MIDIDIR)/ # this line begins with a tab

$(PDFDIR):
    mkdir $(PDFDIR) # this line begins with a tab

$(MIDIDIR):
    mkdir $(MIDIDIR) # this line begins with a tab

common := symphonyDefs.ily

notes := \
    cello.ily \
    horn.ily \
    oboe.ily \
    viola.ily \
    violinOne.ily \
    violinTwo.ily

# The dependencies of the movements.
$(piece)I.pdf: $(piece)I.ly $(notes) $(common)
$(piece)II.pdf: $(piece)II.ly $(notes) $(common)
$(piece)III.pdf: $(piece)III.ly $(notes) $(common)
$(piece)IV.pdf: $(piece)IV.ly $(notes) $(common)

# The dependencies of the full score.
$(piece).pdf: $(piece).ly $(notes) $(common)

# The dependencies of the parts.
$(piece)-cello.pdf: $(piece)-cello.ly cello.ily $(common)
$(piece)-horn.pdf: $(piece)-horn.ly horn.ily $(common)
$(piece)-oboe.pdf: $(piece)-oboe.ly oboe.ily $(common)
$(piece)-viola.pdf: $(piece)-viola.ly viola.ily $(common)
$(piece)-violinOne.pdf: $(piece)-violinOne.ly violinOne.ily $(common)
$(piece)-violinTwo.pdf: $(piece)-violinTwo.ly violinTwo.ily $(common)

```

```

# Type `make score` to generate the full score of all four
# movements as one file.
.PHONY: score
score: $(piece).pdf

# Type `make parts` to generate all parts.
# Type `make symphony-foo.pdf` to generate the part for instrument 'foo'.
# Example: `make symphony-cello.pdf`.
.PHONY: parts
parts: $(piece)-cello.pdf \
      $(piece)-violinOne.pdf \
      $(piece)-violinTwo.pdf \
      $(piece)-viola.pdf \
      $(piece)-oboe.pdf \
      $(piece)-horn.pdf

# Type `make movements` to generate files for the
# four movements separately.
.PHONY: movements
movements: $(piece)I.pdf \
           $(piece)II.pdf \
           $(piece)III.pdf \
           $(piece)IV.pdf

all: score parts movements

```

There are special complications on the Windows platform. After downloading and installing GNU Make for Windows, you must set the correct path in the system's environment variables so that the DOS shell can find the Make program. To do this, right-click on "My Computer," then choose Properties and Advanced. Click Environment Variables, and then in the System Variables pane, highlight Path, click edit, and add the path to the GNU Make executable file, which will look something like this:

```
C:\Program Files\GnuWin32\bin
```

The makefile itself has to be altered to handle different shell commands and to deal with spaces that are present in some default system directories. Windows also has a different default extension for midi files.

```

## WINDOWS VERSION
##
piece := symphony
LILY_CMD := lilypond -ddelete-intermediate-files \
              -dno-point-and-click

# get the 8.3 name of CURDIR (workaround for spaces in PATH)
workdir := $(shell for /f "tokens=*" %%b in ("$(CURDIR)") \
do @echo %%~sb)

.SUFFIXES: .ly .ily .pdf .mid

.DEFAULT_GOAL := score

PDFDIR := PDF

```

```

MIDIDIR := MIDI

VPATH := \
  $(workdir)/Scores \
  $(workdir)/Parts \
  $(workdir)/Notes \
  $(workdir)/$(PDFDIR) \
  $(workdir)/$(MIDIDIR)

%.pdf %.mid: %.ly | $(PDFDIR) $(MIDIDIR)
  $(LILY_CMD) $< # this line begins with a tab
  move /Y "$*.pdf" $(PDFDIR)/ # this line begins with a tab
  move /Y "$*.mid" $(MIDIDIR)/ # this line begins with a tab

$(PDFDIR):
  mkdir $(PDFDIR)/ # this line begins with a tab

$(MIDIDIR):
  mkdir $(MIDIDIR)/ # this line begins with a tab

notes := \
  cello.ily \
  figures.ily \
  horn.ily \
  oboe.ily \
  trioString.ily \
  viola.ily \
  violinOne.ily \
  violinTwo.ily

common := symphonyDefs.ily

$(piece)I.pdf: $(piece)I.ly $(notes) $(common)
$(piece)II.pdf: $(piece)II.ly $(notes) $(common)
$(piece)III.pdf: $(piece)III.ly $(notes) $(common)
$(piece)IV.pdf: $(piece)IV.ly $(notes) $(common)

$(piece).pdf: $(piece).ly $(notes) $(common)

$(piece)-cello.pdf: $(piece)-cello.ly cello.ily $(common)
$(piece)-horn.pdf: $(piece)-horn.ly horn.ily $(common)
$(piece)-oboe.pdf: $(piece)-oboe.ly oboe.ily $(common)
$(piece)-viola.pdf: $(piece)-viola.ly viola.ily $(common)
$(piece)-violinOne.pdf: $(piece)-violinOne.ly violinOne.ily $(common)
$(piece)-violinTwo.pdf: $(piece)-violinTwo.ly violinTwo.ily $(common)

.PHONY: score
score: $(piece).pdf

.PHONY: parts
parts: $(piece)-cello.pdf \
  $(piece)-violinOne.pdf \
  $(piece)-violinTwo.pdf \
  $(piece)-viola.pdf \
  $(piece)-oboe.pdf \
  $(piece)-horn.pdf

```



```
.PHONY: movements
movements: $(piece)I.pdf \
            $(piece)II.pdf \
            $(piece)III.pdf \
            $(piece)IV.pdf

all: score parts movements
```

The next Makefile is for a lilypond-book document done in LaTeX. This project has an index, which requires that the latex command be run twice to update links. Output files are all stored in the out directory for .pdf output and in the htmlout directory for the html output.

```
SHELL = /bin/sh
FILE = myproject
OUTDIR = out
WEBDIR = htmlout
VIEWER = acroread
BROWSER = firefox

LILYBOOK_PDF = lilypond-book --output=$(OUTDIR) --pdf $(FILE).lytex
LILYBOOK_HTML = lilypond-book --output=$(WEBDIR) $(FILE).lytex

PDF = cd $(OUTDIR) && pdflatex $(FILE)
HTML = cd $(WEBDIR) && latex2html $(FILE)
INDEX = cd $(OUTDIR) && makeindex $(FILE)
PREVIEW = $(VIEWER) $(OUTDIR)/$(FILE).pdf &

all: pdf web keep

pdf:
    $(LILYBOOK_PDF) # this line begins with a tab
    $(PDF) # this line begins with a tab
    $(INDEX) # this line begins with a tab
    $(PDF) # this line begins with a tab
    $(PREVIEW) # this line begins with a tab

web:
    $(LILYBOOK_HTML) # this line begins with a tab
    $(HTML) # this line begins with a tab
    cp -R $(WEBDIR)/$(FILE)/ ./ # this line begins with a tab
    $(BROWSER) $(FILE)/$(FILE).html & # this line begins with a tab

keep: pdf
    # the next line begins with a tab
    cp $(OUTDIR)/$(FILE).pdf $(FILE).pdf

clean:
    rm -rf $(OUTDIR) # begin with tab # this line begins with a tab

web-clean:
    rm -rf $(WEBDIR) # begin with tab # this line begins with a tab

archive:
    # the next line begins with a tab
```

```
tar -cvvf myproject.tar \  
    --exclude=out/* \  
    --exclude=htmlout/* \  
    --exclude=myproject/* \  
    --exclude=*midi \  
    --exclude=*pdf \  
    --exclude=*~ \  
    ../MyProject/*
```

TODO: make this thing work on Windows

The previous makefile does not work on Windows. An alternative for Windows users would be to create a simple batch file containing the build commands. This will not keep track of dependencies the way a makefile does, but it at least reduces the build process to a single command. Save the following code as `build.bat` or `build.cmd`. The batch file can be run at the DOS prompt or by simply double-clicking its icon.

```
lilypond-book --output=out --pdf myproject.lytex  
cd out  
pdflatex myproject  
makeindex myproject  
pdflatex myproject  
cd ..  
copy out\myproject.pdf MyProject.pdf
```

See also

This manual: [Command-line usage](#), [lilypond-book](#).

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PREAMBLE

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B Index

A

ABC — Invoking `abc2ly`
 Aborted (core dumped) — Error messages
 Articulate project — MIDI articulation

C

call trace — Error messages
 chroot jail, running inside — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 Coda Technology — Invoking `etf2ly`
 coloring, syntax — Text editor support
 command-line options for `lilypond` — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 convert-ly — Updating files with `convert-ly`
 convert-ly — Why does the syntax change?

D

directory, redirect output — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 docbook — Running `lilypond-book`
 DocBook, adding music — Running `lilypond-book`
 documents, adding music — Running `lilypond-book`
 dvips — Invoking `lilypond-book`

E

editors — Text editor support
 emacs — Text editor support
 enigma — Invoking `etf2ly`
 Enigma Transport Format — Invoking `etf2ly`
 error — Error messages
 error messages — Error messages
 errors, message format — Error messages
 ETF — Invoking `etf2ly`
 Evince — Extra configuration for Evince
 expression evaluation, Scheme — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 External programs, generating LilyPond files — Other formats

F

fatal error — Error messages
 file searching — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 file size, output — Enabling point and click
 Finale — Invoking `etf2ly`

format, output — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 fragments, music — Other programs

H

\header in LaTeX documents — LaTeX
 HTML — Running `lilypond-book`
 HTML, adding music — Running `lilypond-book`
 HTML, embeddable SVG scores — Basic command-line options for LilyPond

I

invoking dvips — Invoking `lilypond-book`
 Invoking `lilypond` — Basic command-line options for LilyPond

L

LANG — Environment variables
 LaTeX — Running `lilypond-book`
 LaTeX, adding music — Running `lilypond-book`
 LibreOffice.org — OpenOffice and LibreOffice
 LILYPOND_DATADIR — Environment variables
 LILYPOND_LOCALEDIR — Environment variables
 LILYPOND_LOGLEVEL — Environment variables
 LILYPOND_RELOCDIR — Environment variables
 loglevel — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 LuaTeX — LuaTeX
 ly2video — `ly2video`
 lyx — LuaTeX

M

make — Make and Makefiles
 makefiles — Make and Makefiles
 MIDI — Invoking `midi2ly`
 MIDI — MIDI articulation
 MIDI, synchronized video — `ly2video`
 modes, editor — Text editor support
 music fragments, quoting — Other programs
 musicology — An example of a musicological document
 MusicXML — Invoking `musicxml2ly`

O

OOoLilyPond — OpenOffice and LibreOffice
 OpenOffice.org — OpenOffice and LibreOffice
 options, command line — Basic command-line options for LilyPond

outline fonts — Invoking `lilypond-book`
 output, directory — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 output, format — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 output, PDF (Portable Document Format) — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 output, PNG (Portable Network Graphics) — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 output, PS (PostScript) — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 output, setting file name — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 output, SVG (Scalable Vector Graphics) — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 output, verbosity — Basic command-line options for LilyPond

P

PDF (Portable Document Format), output — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 PNG (Portable Network Graphics), output — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 point and click — Point and click
 point and click, command line — Advanced command-line options for LilyPond
 PostScript (PS), output — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 preview image — HTML
 Programming error — Error messages
 PS (PostScript), output — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 pspdfopt — Basic command-line options for LilyPond

Q

quoting, music fragments — Other programs

R

relocation — Relocation

S

Scheme error — Error messages
 Scheme, expression evaluation — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 score, creating videos — `ly2video`
 search path — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 SVG (Scalable Vector Graphics), output — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 switches — Basic command-line options for LilyPond
 syntax coloring — Text editor support

T

texi — Running `lilypond-book`
 texinfo — Running `lilypond-book`
 texinfo — Running `lilypond-book`
 Texinfo, adding music — Running `lilypond-book`
 thumbnail — HTML

[titling and lilypond-book — LaTeX](#)
[titling in HTML — HTML](#)
[trace, Scheme — Error messages](#)
[type1 fonts — Invoking lilypond-book](#)

U

[Updating a LilyPond file — Updating files with `convert-ly`](#)
[updating old input files — Why does the syntax change?](#)

V

[videos, with scrolling score — `ly2video`](#)
[vim — Text editor support](#)

W

[warning — Error messages](#)
[web pages, SVG scores embeddable — Basic command-line options for LilyPond](#)